



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Modi flags 'weaponisation' of tech, critical minerals, calls for Brics unity

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India on Sunday flagged concerns over the "weaponisation" of technology and critical minerals at the Brics Summit, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi calling for greater cooperation within the grouping to develop solutions that can be extended to countries of the Global South to foster inclusive global growth.

Modi did not name any countries while making these remarks at the outreach session of the summit, attended by leaders of the 10 member states and as many partner countries, though his comments appeared to be aimed at China, whose restrictions on exports of both rare earths and critical hi-tech equipment in recent years have impacted India.

The concluding session of the two-day Brics Summit hosted by India was focused on the theme of "Resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability: Shaping the future for inclusive global growth", and Modi emphasised that the strength of Brics lies in its diversity and cooperation.

"The weaponisation of technology and critical minerals can hinder our shared progress. Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in the adoption of technology," he said, speaking in Hindi.

Brics members are "rooted in different realities", but can rise together through cooperation, he noted. At the same time, solutions developed by Brics should be made adaptable and accessible to meet the needs of the Global



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other world leaders on the concluding day of the two-day Brics summit in New Delhi on Sunday.

PMO

South because the bloc has promoted inclusive global growth. Against the backdrop of India positioning itself as the voice of the Global South, Modi said the confidence of developing countries in Brics has grown because their views are heard within the grouping, their experiences are respected and "solutions are developed not for them, but together with them".

The increasing resilience of continued on →10

morestories

Congress, BJP trade barbs over summit menu →P7

Defence, trade in focus as Modi holds bilaterals →P7

PUTIN PITCHES GRAIN INSURANCE SYSTEM, MARKET INITIATIVE

Russia on Sunday proposed a new insurance mechanism and a collaborative initiative for the grain market for Brics member states, with President Vladimir Putin urging the grouping to adopt a holistic approach towards pressing global challenges. Putin proposed the initiatives as the Brics member states and partner countries came together for an outreach session at the concluding day of the Brics Summit hosted by India against the backdrop of wide-ranging sanctions imposed by the West on Russia for the invasion of Ukraine. →P7

A world without rules is like a crossroads without traffic lights... Fairness and justice are universal aspirations, and international rules must be written by all countries. **XI JINPING,** Chinese President

...In today's interconnected world, no crisis remains confined to a single region. Therefore, within the Brics group, we have placed special emphasis on strengthening resilience. **NARENDRA MODI,** Prime Minister

As global challenges keep surfacing, we should... address both symptoms and root causes... Global South should jointly tackle traditional and non-traditional security threats **VLADIMIR PUTIN,** Russian President

Iran, UAE agreed to put past aside, says Pezeshkian

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Iran wants to make a fresh start with the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and look to the future, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Sunday, a day after his surprise meeting with Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Khalid bin Mohamed on the margins of the Brics Summit in New Delhi.

The meeting was held even as Iran and the UAE set aside their differences over the West Asia conflict to facilitate a joint declaration at the Brics Summit on Saturday. Few details have emerged about the meeting, held ahead of a planned gathering of Iranian officials with their counterparts from Gulf states and Iraq in Oman on Monday to discuss an agreement on the Strait of Hormuz.

"We had a good conversation with the Crown Prince of Abu

We had a good conversation with the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, and agreed to put the past behind us and look to the future

MASOUD PEZESHKIAN, Iranian President

Dhabi, and agreed to put the past behind us and look to the future," Pezeshkian told Iranian reporters after the conclusion of the Brics Summit. He didn't provide further details.

Iran's foreign ministry said in a statement on Friday that the meeting in Oman is meant to "promote better understanding among the countries of the region and help strengthen continued on →10

Xi: Will lead creation of open source AI for Brics

NEW DELHI: China will lead the creation of an open source artificial intelligence (AI) with an open ecosystem for the Brics grouping, President Xi Jinping said on Sunday against the backdrop of intense competition between Beijing and Washington in the sector. During the outreach session of the Brics Summit, Xi also proposed a trade and investment facilitation initiative, digital

industry cooperation initiative, intelligent manufacturing cooperation initiative and science and technology talent initiative.

"China will be a pioneer in establishing a Brics AI open source community, support cooperation in developing and applying LLMs, hold specialised AI seminars and training courses, and build an open ecosystem for AI," Xi said. →P7

A rain-soaked welcome for Bappa



Umbrellas in hand, devotees braved the torrential rain that lashed the city on Sunday to bring Ganpati idols home, a day before Ganesh Chaturthi.

SATISH BATE/ HT PHOTO

Indian seafarer missing after tanker hit off coast of Oman

Rezaul H Laskar and Yogesh Naik

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW INDIA/MUMBAI: India on Sunday condemned an attack on a Panama-flagged oil tanker that resulted in one Indian seafarer being reported missing, and said the targeting of merchant shipping and civilian infrastructure is unacceptable.

Thirteen other Indian seafarers who were part of the crew of MT

El Gaia were rescued following the attack off the coast of Oman, the external affairs ministry said.

A report prepared by Directorate of Maritime Administration said that the vessel was struck by an unknown projectile while transiting the Strait of Hormuz. The vessel has a total 25 crew members, comprising 14 Indian nationals and 11 Pakistanis. Preliminary information indicates that two crew mem-

continued on →10

LIKE VENEZUELA, U.S. MAY STAY IN IRAN AND KEEP OIL, SAYS TRUMP

US President Donald Trump suggested on Sunday that America could stay in Iran and "keep the oil", drawing a parallel with a US push to take control of fifth of Venezuela's vast oil reserves.

"We'll ultimately get out [of Iran], unless we decide to stay and keep the oil like Venezuela," Trump said. **REUTERS**

UCC TO BE ROLLED OUT ACROSS ALL NDA STATES BY 2029, SAYS SHAH

Faisal Malik

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will be implemented in all states governed by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its allies by 2029.

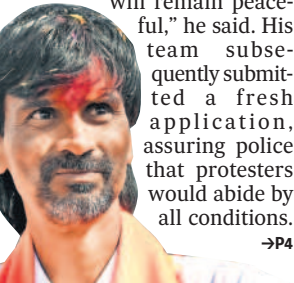
"I am confident that we will implement the UCC in all 21 states governed by the BJP and NDA before 2029," he said in Mumbai. Four BJP-ruled states have so far passed the UCC legislation. →P4

POLICE REFUSES JARANGE-PATIL PERMISSION TO MARCH TO MUMBAI

Faisal Malik

faisal.malik@htlive.com

MUMBAI: Police on Sunday denied permission to Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil for his planned march into Mumbai and subsequent hunger strike from September 19, citing security concerns amid Ganeshotsav. Undeterred, Jarange-Patil said he remained firm on his plan. "We will go to Mumbai and this is final. But we will remain peaceful," he said. His team subsequently submitted a fresh application, assuring police that protesters would abide by all conditions. →P4



NOW, INDIA REFUSE WOMEN'S ASIA CUP TROPHY FROM NAQVI

CHANDIGARH: India beat Sri Lanka by 72 runs to win the Women's T20 Asia Cup on Sunday but refused to accept the trophy from Pakistan minister Mohsin Naqvi. "BCCI has decided to continue with the same position we took during the men's Asia Cup," BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said. →P2

→VANDE MATARAM PLAYED BEFORE INDIA-AFGHANISTAN T20I, P11

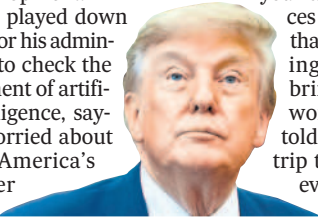
Trump dismisses calls for slowing AI development

DOONBEG, IRELAND: US President Donald Trump on Sunday likened critics of AI to "very negative forces" bringing up scenarios that will not happen amid calls from industry figures to slow development.

Trump played down the need for his administration to check the development of artificial intelligence, saying he worried about ceding America's edge over China in

a global competition and that winning would help would address the risks from the advancing technology.

"We can put guardrails, we can do this and that, but I think you have a lot of negative forces that are bringing it up that... shouldn't be bringing it up, and they're bringing up things that won't happen," Trump told reporters during his trip to Ireland. "But whoever wins with AI wins." →P9



HT WISHES ITS READERS A HAPPY GANESH CHATURTHI



The offices of Hindustan Times, Mumbai, will remain closed on Monday, Sept 14, 2026, on account of Ganesh Chaturthi. There will be no edition of this paper on Tuesday, Sept 15, 2026.

New Labour Codes have redefined Employer obligations on Gratuity and Leave Encashment.

Our expertise will ensure the compliance becomes Simple, Reliable, and Future - ready.

Presenting

LIC's GROUP SCHEMES

New Group Gratuity Cash Accumulation Plan - UIN: 512N281V04

New Group Leave Encashment Plan - UIN: 512N282V04

New Group Superannuation Cash Accumulation Plan - UIN: 512N274V03

Group Post Retirement Medical Benefit Scheme - UIN: 512N352V01

Group Benefits Secure Plan - UIN: 512N367V01

Salient Features:

Scientific funding

Attractive Returns

Benefit of insurance protection

Income Tax Benefits as per Rules

Multiple options for annuity payments

For more details, email to groupbusiness@licindia.com or contact your Agent/nearest LIC P&GS unit

Call Centre Services (022) 6827 6827

Visit: www.licindia.in

Follow us :

LIC India Forever | IRDAI Regn No.: 512

BEWARE OF SPURIOUS PHONE CALLS AND ECTITIOUS / FRAUDULENT OFFERS. IRDAI or its officials do not involve in any activities of insurance business like selling insurance policies, announcing bonus or investment of premiums, refund of amounts. Policyholders or the prospects receiving such phone calls are requested to lodge a police complaint. For more details on risk factors, terms and conditions, please read sales brochure carefully before concluding a sale.

LIC
भारतीय जीवन बीमा निगम
LIFE INSURANCE CORPORATION OF INDIA

Har Pal Aapke Saath

LICP1/2025-26/36/Eng

NUMBER THEORY

PART-I

El Nino and long-term monsoon rain patterns

By Abhishek Jha

Monsoon 2026 was widely expected to have a large rainfall deficit. This is because an El Nino – a cyclical warming of the central-eastern Pacific Ocean that crimps June-September rain in India even before its winter peak – had developed by April or May, depending on the index used. At any rate, it had enough time to suppress monsoon rainfall. However, even those casually interested in the monsoon would have noticed that there is wide geographic variation in its performance, with some regions quite wet. Why is this the case? The answer to this question can not only help us foresee the impact of El Nino on the monsoon, but also the wider implications of a dry monsoon. This two-part series will do just that.

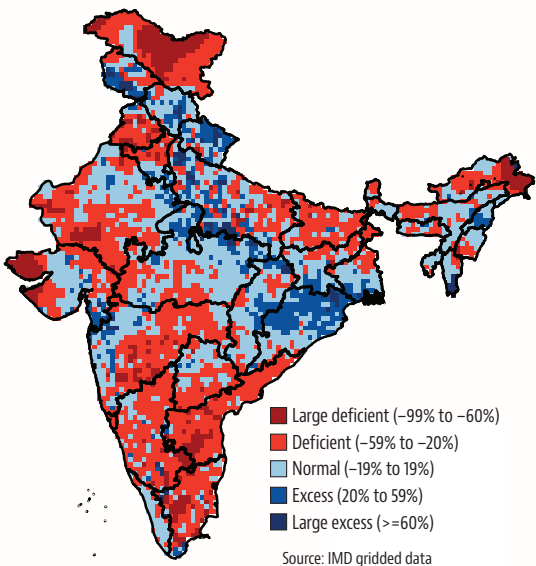
SANJEEV VERMA/HT



1 El Nino has created drought-like conditions for only half of the country

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) tracks rainfall performance using departure from the Long Period Average (LPA), currently defined as the average rainfall during 1971-2020. It classifies rain as “deficient” if a place has a deficit of 20%-60% from the LPA, and as “large deficient” if the deficit is 60% or more. Surpluses of the same degree are classified as “excess” and “large excess”, with a departure of under 20% classified as “normal”. As of September 13, just about 50% of the country was in the deficient categories. The rest was either in the normal or excess categories. Clearly, El Nino’s relationship with the monsoon has not been of much consequence to almost half of the country. To be sure, a deficient monsoon in half the country is pretty bad in aggregate terms. This is reflected in the country-level statistics, where there was a 12.8% deficit, the highest since 2009 and 11th highest since 1901. The geographical distribution of the deficit, however, highlights that an El Nino year has not brought drought everywhere.

Departure of 2026 rain from LPA: June 1 – September 13



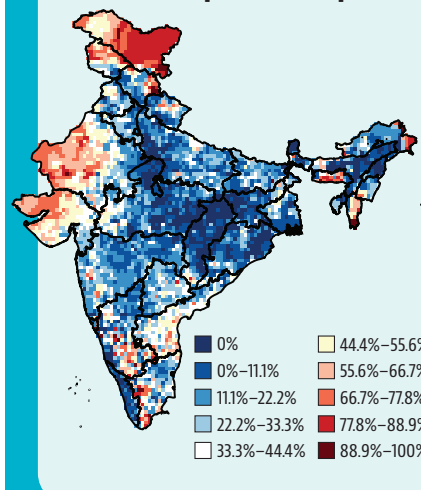
Source: IMD gridded data

2 Part of this has to do with geographic diversity in El Nino's relation with monsoon

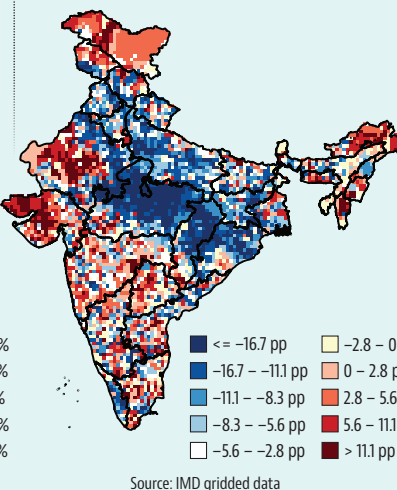
Part of the trend described could be the result of the fact that El Nino does not suppress rainfall uniformly across India. This can be seen in the fraction of El Nino years in the 1996-2025 period (when there were nine El Nino-affected monsoons) when different parts of India were deficient. Only 51% of the country was deficient in even three of those years. One reason for this is that El Nino’s relationship with deficient rain has weakened in some

parts of India recently. Some of that changed relationship might have driven the 2026 monsoon. A majority of the area that is not deficient in 2026 is the area where relationship with El Nino has weakened and vice versa. To be sure, this is a crude way of describing a weakening of monsoon’s relationship with Pacific temperature trends, not just an El Nino, which describes only warmer than normal temperatures.

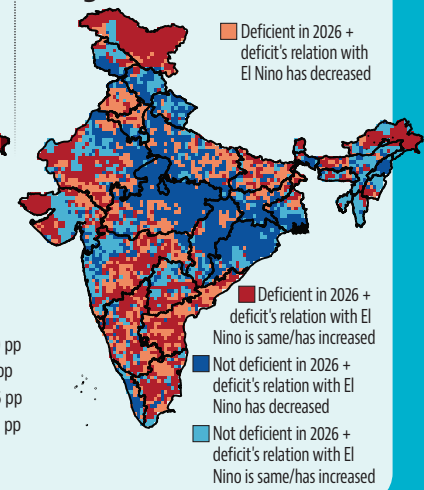
Share of El Nino years in 1996–2025 period with deficient rain in June 1–September 31 period



Change in share of El Nino years with deficient rain in monsoon: 1996–2025 vs 1950–1980



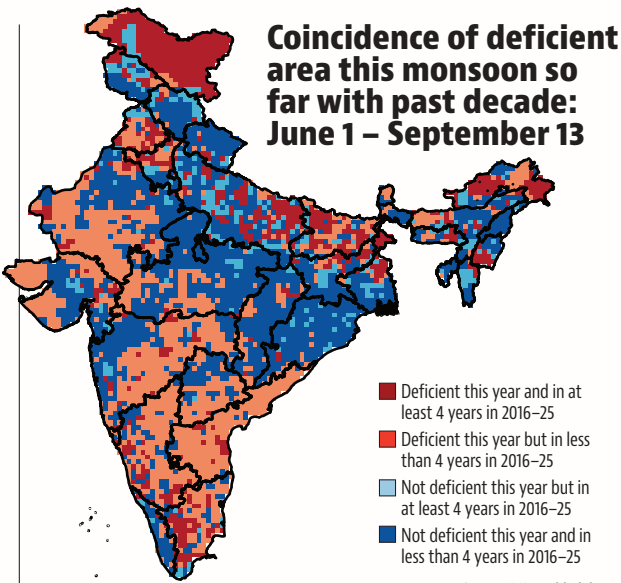
Coincidence of deficient area this monsoon so far with change in relation to El Nino



Source: IMD gridded data

3 And some of it is likely because of things unrelated to El Nino

While assessing El Nino’s impact on the monsoon, it is important to consider that other factors also affect monsoon and that a weak relationship with El Nino does not mean good rain in every El Nino year. For example, half of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, around 45% of Punjab and Haryana, and around a third of West Bengal and Jharkhand were deficient in four or more years in 2016-25, although the decade had just two El Nino monsoons. This implies that a deficient area may be more widespread in an El Nino monsoon, but important cereal-producing states have been dry recently irrespective of El Nino. What does this persistent dryness mean for food production and water availability? The next part will try to answer these questions with another set of maps.



Source: IMD gridded data

{ SPORT } THIRD GRAND SLAM TITLE

Rybakina defeats Sabalenka to claim first US Open crown



Last month, Elena Rybakina wasn’t sure if she would be able to play a match at the US Open. She played, and won, all seven. Last year, on September 15, she was world No.10. On September 14, 2026, she will be world No.1. As the US Open champion. That’s some stamp of statement to go with the turnaround tale. The Russian-born Kazakh wasn’t done dethroning the incumbent from the top spot. She took her title too on Saturday. Rybakina defeated two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 for her first US Open crown after a high stakes, high quality final. This was Rybakina’s third Grand Slam win, and second this year after beating the Belarusian at the Australian Open too. →P12

{ MY INDIA } IN WEST BENGAL

23-yr-old man kills girlfriend, caught with her body on bike



A 23-year-old man has been arrested in Purulia district of West Bengal for allegedly killing his girlfriend over suspicion of cheating, police said on Sunday, adding that the accused was caught carrying her body in a sack tied to his motorcycle while attempting to dump it. “The accused, Amit Kumar Mahato, was caught at a police checkpoint on the state highway to Jamshedpur while attempting to dump the body. The body of the victim, Pritika Mahato, 20, was found inside a sack tied to the rear seat of the motorcycle,” a police officer said on anonymity. The officer said the incident took place on Saturday, adding that the accused confessed to killing the woman over suspicion of cheating. HTC

Apex court seals docs’ liability under consumer protection law

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has put a final judicial seal on the liability of doctors and hospitals under consumer protection law, as it dismissed a curative petition challenging its landmark 1995 ruling that had brought medical services within the ambit of the Consumer Protection Act (CPA).

A five-judge bench of justices Vikram Nath, BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Prashant Kumar Mishra and KV Viswanathan dismissed the curative petition filed by Dr Rajeev D Joshi of the Medico Legal Society of India, holding that no case was made out within the parameters laid down for entertaining a curative petition.

The brief order, passed on September 9, effectively closes the latest challenge to the 1995 judgment in Indian Medical Association Vs VP Shantha, under which patients can approach consumer forums against doctors and hospitals for deficiency in medical services.

“We have gone through the curative petition and the relevant documents. In our opinion, no case is made out within the parameters indicated” in the Supreme Court’s 2002 judgment in Rupa Ashok Hurra Vs Ashok Hurra, the bench said, dismissing the plea.

The development comes after the apex court had declined in November 2024 to reconsider the Shantha ruling, in a reference triggered by its judgment excluding lawyers from the CPA’s purview.

The issue had arisen after a three-judge bench was asked to examine whether the 1995 ruling required reconsideration in light

THE 1995 SHANTHA RULING HAD HELD THAT MEDICAL SERVICES RENDERED FOR CONSIDERATION CONSTITUTED ‘SERVICE’ UNDER CONSUMER LAW

of the court’s decision that legal professionals could not be proceeded against under consumer law for deficiency in service.

The bench, however, held that the reference itself was unnecessary. It pointed out that the earlier judgment on lawyers had specifically dealt with the legal profession and that the exclusion of lawyers from the CPA did not, by itself, warrant reopening the law governing medical professionals.

“The question as to whether the other professionals excluding legal profession could be covered under the Act can be considered in appropriate cases, having a factual foundation,” the bench had said in 2024.

The court also underlined the distinct nature of the relationship between medical professionals and patients while declining to disturb the Shantha judgment. The 1995 ruling had held that medical services rendered for consideration constituted “service” under the consumer law, making doctors and hospitals answerable before consumer fora for deficiencies.

The 2024 controversy arose from a May 2024 judgment by a two-judge bench, which held that advocates could not be sued

before consumer courts for alleged deficiency in service. The court reasoned that the legal profession had a unique role in the administration of justice and that legal services could not be equated with commercial services rendered by businessmen or traders.

In the same judgment, the bench had observed that the Shantha ruling “deserves to be revisited”, prompting the subsequent reference.

That opening for reconsideration has now been firmly shut since the curative petition was the latest attempt to unsettle the legal position that has governed medical consumer litigation for more than three decades.

With the five-judge bench finding no ground to invoke the narrowly defined curative jurisdiction, the Shantha framework remains intact — patients can continue to seek redress under consumer protection law against doctors and hospitals for deficiency in medical services.

To be sure, the Bolam Test — a standard that has long been recognised in medical negligence cases — has been consistently reaffirmed by the Supreme Court. Originating from the 1957 English case Bolam Vs Friern Hospital Management Committee, this test states that a doctor is not negligent if they act in accordance with a practice accepted by a responsible body of medical professionals.

In the Indian context, the Supreme Court endorsed the Bolam Test in the case of Jacob Mathews Vs State of Punjab (2005), holding that only if a doctor lacks requisite skills or fails to exercise reasonable competence should liability be imposed.

WANT TO RESET BILATERAL TIES WITH INDIA, SAYS B'DESH MINISTER

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

DHAKA: Bangladesh on Sunday said it wants to “reset” its relationship with India and build a new bilateral engagement based on mutual interests, while describing ties during the tenure of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina as “uncomfortable”.

The remarks by state minister for foreign affairs Humaiun Kobir came two days after Bangladesh on Thursday said Prime Minister Tarique Rahman would not participate in the Brics Summit hosted by India as he was not invited to the event, with the invitation instead extended to the BIMSTEC chair.

India had invited Rahman to attend the summit as chairman of the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC), while a separate bilateral invitation had been in place since February.

Bangladesh wants to “reset” its bilateral relationship with India, Kobir told reporters in Dhaka.

“We want to move towards a new relationship, which should be done through bilateral discussions, not through a multilateral forum,” he said.

Kobir said Bangladesh needs to move beyond what he described as an “excessive preoccupation” with India and approach its relationship with New Delhi in a balanced manner, focusing on mutual interests and treating it as part of its broader engagement with other countries.

Indian scientists control quantum entanglement loss with timed move

Kabir Firaque

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: One of the fundamental concepts in quantum physics is entanglement, which is key to quantum computing. Entanglement, where the quantum properties of two particles can only be described together, no matter how far apart they are, however, is fleeting, and can disintegrate when entangled particles interact with the environment. This places a limit on how long quantum information can survive before what is known as “entanglement sudden death”.

Now, scientists at the Raman Research Institute (RRI) in Bengaluru have found a way to make quantum entanglement last longer. They use a “flip operation” with precise timing. This can not only delay sudden death but also prevent or hasten it.

The team, in collaboration with researchers at the University of Calgary and Louisiana State University, has published its findings in the journal Physical Review A. The study was funded by the National Quantum Mission.

Getting entangled

A quantum particle can exist in either an excited state (higher energy) or a ground state (lower energy). When two particles get entangled, their states become linked: the combined system acts as a single, coordinated system rather than two independent

THE FLIP OPERATION ALLOWS QUANTUM INFORMATION TO SURVIVE LONGER BY DELAYING OR PREVENTING ‘ENTANGLEMENT Sudden DEATH’

ent objects — a property key to quantum computing. For example, either particle may be found in the excited state while the other is in the ground state.

When interacting with the environment, however, the excited-state component tends to decay into the ground-state component. This weakens the entanglement, which can vanish over time.

Timing and control

The research team sought a way to delay sudden death — and found one. They used an optical setup that exploits a key property of light, whose particles, called photons, are quantum particles. The property is called polarisation, which can be vertical or horizontal

depending on the orientation in which the light waves are oscillating. They took vertical polarisation to represent the excited state and horizontal polarisation the ground state, and applied a flip that swaps the two.

“Swapping” does not mean that one photon was waiting in vertical polarisation and sud-

denly flipped to horizontal, said senior professor Urbasi Sinha, group leader of the Quantum Information and Computing (QuIC) lab at RRI. Her colleague Saumya Ranjan Behera is the study’s lead author.

“What we control is the probability that the vertical component is converted into the horizontal one. The identification of vertical with ‘excited’ and horizontal with ‘ground’ is a choice of encoding. A photon does not have atomic ground and excited states in this sense. What matters is that our apparatus creates a one-way quantum map: one state is stable, and the other can decay into it,” Sinha told HT.

The team applied the flip using a waveplate, an optical device that can change the polarisation of light. Alteration of polarisation in itself is not new. What the team achieved was control over how the entanglement subsequently decayed. It was a matter of timing: the result depended on when a single flip was introduced during the decay process.

“What is different here is that a single well-timed operation is enough to steer the entanglement dynamics. We also show theoretically that, within the class of strategies we studied, using more such operations does not help; it does worse,” Sinha said.

“Also,” she added, “the result is not only that entanglement lasts longer. Depending on when the same operation is applied, it can do three different things: prevent sudden death, delay it, or hasten it. That is why timing is the central point.”

What it means

Across quantum platforms, one of the central obstacles is decoherence, or the loss of a system’s quantum properties on interaction with the environment. Sinha cautioned against interpreting the results as a solution to the problem. This is one of the big challenges in quantum computing.

“We have not solved coherence. What we show is more specific: for an important kind of noise called amplitude damping, the timing of one operation can change the fate of entanglement. Our work suggests that timing could become part of the control toolbox for quantum systems,” Sinha said.

“There is a real removal of sudden death in that regime, but it is not immortality. We are steering the route taken by the system while it decoheres,” she said.

Asked about hastening sudden death, Sinha said its importance is evidential. “If the operation could only delay or protect entanglement, one might think it was simply a preservation effect. But the same operation can also make sudden death occur earlier, depending only on when it is applied,” she said. That shows that timing is genuinely steering the dynamics.

There is another takeaway, in terms of theoretical physics. Two standard models of quantum physics address the basic question of how quantum systems can lose information: independently, as if each particle has its own environment, or collectively, as if they share one. “The work connects the two standard ways,” Sinha said.

Jarange denied nod for hunger strike at Azad Maidan

Faisal Malik
faisal.malik@htlive.com

MUMBAI: The police on Sunday denied permission to Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil for his march into the city, followed by an indefinite hunger strike from September 19, citing potential security concerns during the ongoing Ganeshotsav celebrations. Undeterred, Jarange-Patil said he remains firm on his plan. "We will go to Mumbai and this is final. But we will remain peaceful," Jarange-Patil said in response to a question on the police denial.

The activist's team subsequently filed a fresh application seeking permission, assuring the police that the protesters would abide by all conditions and regulations imposed for the agitation. Jarange-Patil had announced on Saturday that he would start his march into Mumbai from Jalna on September 15 and remain at Azad Maidan from September 19 onwards until the government accepted his demand for reservation for the Maratha community under the Kunbi category.

Senior Police Inspector Raju Bidkar of the Azad Maidan Police Station

said permission for the indefinite hunger strike had been denied as the proposed protest could disrupt normal life, particularly in South Mumbai, by affecting schools, hospitals, courts, public transport and healthcare services. Such disruption could potentially lead to a serious law-and-order situation, the police said.

The police also cited the Supreme Court's judgment in Amit Sahni versus Commissioner of Police, regarding the Shaheen Bagh protests, which held that while peaceful protest is protected, public roads and spaces cannot be occupied indefinitely in a manner that causes serious public inconvenience.

The police also cited the Ganeshotsav celebrations beginning in Mumbai from September 14, saying the festivities would require extensive personnel deployment and that holding a protest amid large crowds could raise additional public safety concerns.

City-based Maratha activist and agitation coordinator Virendra Pawar said they plan to challenge the rules imposed by the Mumbai Police for a protest at Azad Maidan. "The police have imposed a long list of conditions for holding a protest, which is unfair," he said.



UCC in 21 NDA-ruled states before 2029, says Amit Shah

Faisal Malik
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said that the governments in 21 states ruled by the BJP-led NDA will introduce a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) before the next parliamentary elections in 2029. He added that discussions were underway with allies regarding the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) across the country, saying that they would "identify and flush out every single illegal infiltrator from India".

Shah made the announcement while detailing the 'Seva Sankalp Abhiyan', a month-long nationwide mass-outreach campaign organised by the BJP and its state governments to commemorate Narendra Modi's 25 years in power, first as Gujarat CM and then as PM.

"We introduced the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in several states. I am confident that we will implement the UCC in all 21 states governed by the BJP-led NDA before 2029... Operations such as the surgical strikes, air strikes, and Operation Sindoor have established a policy of zero tolerance towards terrorism, while security has been prioritised across various sectors," Shah said.

Four BJP-ruled states have so far passed the UCC legislation.



Home Minister Amit Shah with CM Devendra Fadnavis during a press conference in Mumbai on Sunday. ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/HT

Uttarakhand became the first state to enact a UCC law in February 2024 and implement it from January 2025, while Gujarat, Assam and Madhya Pradesh are awaiting presidential assent and notification. Maharashtra, West Bengal and Chhattisgarh have constituted committees to draft a UCC legislation.

UCC is part of a troika of core goals of the BJP, in addition to the Ram Temple and the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu & Kashmir. The party has already achieved the Ram Temple and Article 370 abrogation goals. Article 44 of the Constitution, one of the directive principles of state policy, urges the state to endeavour to secure a

Uniform Civil Code for citizens. But personal matters such as marriage, divorce, inheritance and adoption continued to be governed by religion-specific personal laws since Independence, till Uttarakhand enacted UCC in February 2024.

Shah said that discussions were underway with the allies on the possibility of implementing the NRC exercise across the country. He also said the government was discussing whether the year 1951 should be used as the baseline for the NRC in Manipur. "We are discussing this with our allies and the political parties in Manipur. Once we reach a conclusion, it will be shared publicly," he said. Speaking on Articles 370 and

35A, Shah claimed the BJP government had abrogated them without "a single drop of blood" being shed or a bullet being fired, and said that Kashmir was "now fully integrated with India". He also claimed that the BJP government had brought an end to five decades of Naxalism. "More than 9,000 people have surrendered and today we have taken the North-East on the path of development by signing more than 14 peace agreements in the region," he said.

Earlier, Shah visited the Asiatic Society of Mumbai, where he inaugurated an exhibition showcasing its heritage collection. Speaking on the need to "decolonise" India's history and knowledge systems, Shah said the process did not mean erasing history.

"It has been claimed many times that history is being soiled," he said. "I do not agree. Decolonisation does not mean erasing history; it means making history complete and authentic, and presenting it to the people again from an Indian perspective. The colonisers used history, knowledge, culture and traditions to establish and secure their rule. We are now working to free that same knowledge and move forward with decolonisation."

Shah later visited the Bharat Diamond Bourse to attend a felicitation programme.

{ TEXT AND SUB TEXT } BEHIND THE HEADLINES

Shinde-Jarange bonhomie over?

SHAILESH
GAIKWAD



Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil, who has announced that he will march to Mumbai to press for his demand for Kunbi sub-caste certificates for Marathas, has surprised everyone by training his guns on deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde. Jarange-Patil has accused Shinde of betraying him and alleged that the latter is trying to derail his agitation. On Sunday, he went a step further, alleging that both chief minister Devendra Fadnavis and Shinde are conspiring against him.

Jarange-Patil's attack on Fadnavis is not a surprise, since he has been doing so from day one. His tirade against Shinde, however, is new. The bonhomie between him and Shinde—himself a Maratha—was on full display when the latter was chief minister and even later.

For most of the time since he began his agitation, several BJP leaders were convinced that Shinde, who wanted to be seen as the next Maratha community leader, was encouraging him. But now, on his 11th hunger strike, Jarange-Patil is not sparing Shinde either. So, what has gone wrong?

According to Sena leaders, the activist is expecting Shinde to convince Fadnavis to agree to his demands. Sena leaders, however, are avoiding any direct showdown with the Maratha activist, knowing full well the support he enjoys in the community.

Mehta in a tight spot

Mira Bhayandar MLA Narendra Mehta is in a tight spot. He is facing flak after it came to light that students of a school run by him had been asked not to bring food containing onions, garlic, potatoes and beetroot in their tiffin during the Jain community's Paryushan period. Following strong reactions from various quarters, Mehta clarified that it was only a suggestion. The state education department also began an inquiry after the circular was reportedly found on parents' WhatsApp groups.

On Saturday, he faced fresh criticism after a couple of MNS functionaries posted a video on social media showing them having a meal at Mehta's Seven Eleven Club, where they ordered dishes containing potatoes and onions. "Mehta wants children not to eat onions and potatoes, but the same restrictions are not followed

when it comes to his business," remarked MNS' Mira Bhayandar leader Sachin Pokle. The BJP legislator did not respond to the allegations till Sunday.

'Couple-friendly' hotels irks minister

Revenue minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule seems to be irked with the mushrooming of a hotel chain in his hometown, Nagpur. The brand is famous for couple-friendly accommodation. Last week when he was in Nagpur, he announced that there would be strict monitoring of the hotels following citizens' complaints. "After every two hotels, there is one with this board. Citizens in the nearby area have been complaining to me," he said without specifying the nature of the complaints.

Ministers fume over staff diktat

CM Devendra Fadnavis's decision to send 570 government staffers who were working as "borrowed staff" by ministers for their offices has left many ministers fuming. Some time ago, the chief minister's office (CMO) issued a directive asking all such staffers who were not formally appointed to be sent back to their respective departments from their current informal posting with the ministers' offices. Since September 10, their digital identity-card access for entry in Mantralaya building has reportedly been stopped.

These staffers were working as personal secretaries, assistants and officers on special duty for the ministers, often due to personal preference of the ministers. The drive is apparently part of the CMO's aim to rid Mantralaya of corruption. Some ministers are complaining that the work in their offices is getting affected due to the sudden decision. The CMO, meanwhile, is unfazed.

New state Cong chief

After Sirivella Prasad was appointed as All India Congress Committee in charge of Maharashtra, mediapersons asked state Congress leaders about him. Most of them were clueless. A couple of them quickly did a search on their phones to find out. Unlike Chennithala, Prasad is not a well-known name. Many Congress leaders are sceptical whether he can command the same respect as his predecessor. But then, the leadership is probably looking at resurrecting the party than worrying about coordination among state leaders, it seems.

Rains return to lash city



Following a prolonged dry spell, heavy rains lashed parts of the city on Sunday. Rainfall in the city had dropped sharply after July, with barely any showers in the last month apart from a few passing spells. SATISH BATE/HT PHOTO

SENA MLA FACES COMPLAINT OVER REMARK ON WOMAN'S BODY



This is the third controversy involving Sanjay Gaikwad since last year.

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: After punching a canteen staffer over "stale food" and threatening a publisher over the title of a historical book, Shiv Sena MLA Sanjay Gaikwad has courted controversy yet again, this time over an allegedly obscene remark about a woman's body.

The latest controversy erupted after BJP MLA Shweta Mahale Patil, 42, of the Chikhli Assembly constituency, filed a police complaint against Gaikwad over his response to her remark, "Baap to baap rahega." Gaikwad allegedly followed it with a crude reference to how a woman could claim to be a father and possess a male body. His remarks have been widely criticised on social media as obscene and misogynistic.

The Buldhana police have registered a non-cognisable offence against Gaikwad. An FIR is yet to be registered. The exchange was the latest escalation in a political tussle between Mahale and Gaikwad that began during a birthday celebration for Vidyadhar Mahale, an Officer on Special Duty in the Chief Minister's Office and Shweta Mahale's husband. In July 2025, he assaulted an MLA canteen employee following a dispute over stale food.

In April 2026, Gaikwad abused Kolhapur-based publisher Prashant Ambhi over the title of a book on King Shivaji.

81-yr-old schoolmate meets PM, seeks CBI probe in land dispute

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Asgarbhai Vohra, 81, had studied at the same school in Vadnagar, Gujarat as Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Yet, he did not think of approaching his former schoolmate for help in resolving a land dispute in Bhayandar which he was embroiled in for at least 15 years.

"I did not approach him because he has a bigger responsibility of leading the nation. I did not want to bother him with what I considered a small issue," said Vohra, who stays in Gandhinagar.

A few months ago, though, when he had a phone conversation with Modi, he told the Prime Minister about his problem and sought an appointment.

"I subsequently received a call from the PMO (prime minister's office) informing me that PM Modi would be visiting Mumbai on September 8 to inaugurate the Global Fintech Fest (GFF) at the Jio World Convention Centre, and I was asked to reach there to meet him," he said.

Accordingly, on September 8, Vohra travelled from Gandhinagar to Mumbai, met the prime minister and submitted a letter alleging that his 2,810-square-metre land in Bhayandar East had been illegally grabbed by two builders, and sought a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) inquiry into the matter.

Speaking to Hindustan Times, Vohra said that Modi met him warmly and gave him a positive response about looking into the matter.



Asgarbhai Vohra travelled from Gandhinagar to Mumbai on September 8 to meet the Prime Minister.

MODI MET VOHRA WARMLY AND ASSURED HIM ABOUT LOOKING INTO THE MATTER

"I bought the property around 37 years ago. But in 2011, it was grabbed by two builders, and I have been fighting this battle ever since. Now that I have met the prime minister, I hope to get justice," he told HT.

2,810-sqm plot

According to complaints submitted by Vohra to the police and the Mira-Bhayandar Municipal Corporation, he purchased 2,810 square metres of land on Navghar Road, Bhayandar East, in 1989 via a registered agreement. The property was part of old survey no. 240 and is now identified as survey no. 185, hissa no. 6.

Vohra maintained that

though he had never sold or transferred the property to anyone, it was taken over in 2011, and subsequently divided into two parts — one controlled by Swayam Builders, and another by Seven Eleven Constructions, which Vohra alleged was associated with BJP MLA Narendra Mehta.

In 2015, a first information report regarding the alleged land grab was registered based on Vohra's complaint. A criminal investigation department (CID) probe was subsequently ordered, and the report was submitted in early 2026, he said.

Meanwhile, in 2025, a case was registered against Vohra without giving him an opportunity to present his case. The Mira-Bhayandar Municipal Corporation's town planning department and revenue authorities also granted construction-related permissions despite the dispute over the property, he alleged.

Doctors concerned over QR code display rule

Hepzi Anthony
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The issue of QR codes for Maharashtra's doctors, recently mandated by the Maharashtra Medical Council (MMC), has perturbed the medical fraternity, which has responded with a letter listing its objections.

The MMC, in order to weed out bogus doctors, recently mandated QR code plates to be displayed at clinics to get patients updated authentic information about the doctor and their academic credentials. However, doctors practicing in multiple hospitals and clinics have objected to this as an "impractical suggestion" and asked the MMC to find a middle way.

"Most of our specialists, particularly those working in corporate hospitals, operate out of shared consultation rooms, used by multiple doctors at different times," said Dr Rajendra Nagarkatti, president of the Association of Medical Consultants (AMC), which represents the interests of over 16,000 post-graduate medical specialists in the Mumbai Metropolitan

Region. "How can hospitals put up so many QR codes? Will they have to have a wall full of QR codes plates? Will we have to carry around the QR code plates to our different clinics? Can't we just have the QR codes on our letterheads for people to check? We are all for this move against fake doctors but there are things that need clarification."

The AMC expressed its opposition to the MMC implementation method for QR code plates. While not against the concept, the AMC noted that doctors often practice across multiple facilities, including clinics, diagnostic centres, and hospitals. Requiring physical plates at every location creates redundant compliance, as a doctor holds a single statutory MMC registration. Additionally, the AMC raised concerns over third-party digital platforms collecting and processing doctors' data to fulfil these physical plate requirements. Consequently, members requested that the MMC reconsider its current approach and actively consult medical representatives before initiating any coercive enforcement actions.

33-yr-old Panvel man killed after SUV driver runs him over twice over parking dispute

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NAVI MUMBAI: A 33-year-old Panvel resident died after an SUV driver allegedly ran over him twice, following a dispute over parked two-wheelers outside a hotel in Shiravane on Saturday morning. The driver and his three accomplices allegedly assaulted two other men, including a restaurant manager who tried to intervene, before fleeing from the spot.

Two of the accused, identified as Satish Tayde and Kalim Shaikh, were arrested on Sunday evening after the police went through CCTV footage and analysed their call records. "They left for Karjat after the fight and were headed for Pune. Their vehicle was found at Karjat. We have identified the other two accused as well and will arrest them soon," said ACP Sandesh

THE MULTIPLE ASSAULTS BY THE ACCUSED LED TO THE DEATH OF RANJITSINGH DALJIT SHERGILL, AND INJURIES TO ANOTHER MAN

Naik. The multiple assaults by the accused led to the death of Ranjitsingh Daljit Shergill, 33, while the complainant, Ashutosh Anil Morjkar, 33, sustained serious injuries to his head and hands. According to Morjkar's statement, he and his friend Mubin went to Sunrise Hotel in Shiravane at around 5 am on Saturday for a drink. At around 7 am, the two moved to a neighbouring hotel for food.

Mubin had parked his two-wheeler outside and went out to

smoke a cigarette. When he did not return by 7.45 am, Morjkar stepped outside and saw him arguing with four men. Several two-wheelers parked near the hotel gate had been knocked down, allegedly by the four men. Morjkar said he tried to mediate but the men abused him as well.

Two of the group subsequently left while the other two went towards a Creta compact SUV parked in a lane. Morjkar followed them and suggested that they go to the police station to resolve the dispute. "However, the driver refused and threatened me, saying, 'I will not let you go alive today,'" Morjkar stated in his complaint.

The driver then allegedly reversed the car at high speed and drove into Sujal Vishnu Khedkar, 21, who was standing nearby. He then allegedly drove towards Shergill, who was trying to pacify the group. The com-

plaint stated that the driver reversed and drove forward over Shergill twice before fleeing towards the main road.

The car returned after some time, following which the second accused allegedly emerged with a hockey stick and told Morjkar he would beat him to death with it. He then struck Morjkar on his head and hands.

Morjkar and Khedkar were taken to Meenatai Thackeray Hospital by their acquaintances. Morjkar later learnt at the hospital that Shergill had died at the spot where he was attacked. He provided descriptions of all four accused and stated that he would be able to identify them. The FIR also recorded the registration number of the vehicle as MH 12 UC 7755. The police are investigating the circumstances leading to the dispute and the subsequent attack, including the role of the other two men.

17-ft Ganesha idol collapses in Malad mandap

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: A 17-foot Ganesha idol collapsed while it was being lifted and placed inside a mandap in Malad West on Sunday morning, taking the total number of such cases in the city and suburbs this year to five.

According to the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), the incident was reported by the P/N ward control room around 10.30am from Kachpada Road No. 2, Ramchandra Lane, opposite the Mariamma Mandir, after the crane being used for the

THE INCIDENT HAS RAISED AFRESH CONCERNS OVER THE HANDLING, TRANSPORTATION OF LARGE IDOLS

operation lost balance. The BMC's ward staff, including a junior engineer and a mukadam, rushed to the spot and police were also mobilised.

Civic officials said the collapsed idol would be loaded onto a dumper using a JCB, and taken

to a nearby waterbody for immersion.

Like the Malad incident, the other four incidents of Ganesha idol collapse this year occurred during transportation, arrival processions and installation of idols. The first and most serious of these incidents occurred on August 22 in Bhuleshwar, when a portion of a 22-foot plaster of Paris (POP) idol broke loose from its moorings and came crashing down on people gathered in the procession, killing the president of the Ganesha mandal and a local resident.

On September 8, an idol being

transported from Ghatkopar to Dharavi toppled from a trolley after hitting a speed breaker near Sheetal Talao. Two people sustained minor injuries in the incident. Subsequently, sudden heavy rain and strong winds caused another idol being transported in Nalasopara to lose balance and collapse, though no serious injuries were reported.

The incidents have raised concern over the handling and transportation of large idols, particularly during their movement through crowded roads and while being lifted into mandaps.

BLDG CARETAKER
BOOKED AFTER
LOOSE IRON
GATE FALLS ON
TARDEO WOMAN



Jenny suffered cheekbone and nasal fractures and a severe internal injury to her mouth.

Megha Sood
megha.lood@htlive.com

MUMBAI: Nearly 20 days after a 23-year-old woman suffered multiple fractures when a dilapidated iron entrance gate at Sachinam Heights in Tardeo fell on her, the police have registered an FIR against the building's caretaker for alleged negligence. The incident took place on August 27, when the woman, Jenny Yazdi Dara Bamji, was returning from the Ambamata Temple on the building premises after offering prayers. She sustained an injury to the back of her head, fractures to both cheekbones, a nasal fracture and a severe internal injury to the roof of her mouth (palate). Three of her teeth were also broken.

Following the incident, Jenny's father Yazdi Dara Bamji, 58, a businessman and resident of Zoroastrian Colony, visited the building and checked CCTV footage from its 'B' Wing. He observed that the main entrance had a dilapidated iron gate. He subsequently approached the police and provided details of the incident.

The police have booked the building's caretaker, Vinay Babu Shah, 53, under Section 125(b) (causes grievous hurt negligence and rash action) of BNS. According to the complaint, Shah, who was responsible for maintaining the premises, had allegedly left the iron gate standing without securing or fastening it and without taking necessary safety precautions.

The police said they have issued a notice to Shah directing him to appear before them for further investigation.

BMC set to delete reservation for PAP project in Jogeshwari

Despite spending thousands of crores to create housing for PAPs, BMC considers deleting reservation

Linah Baliga
leena.baliga@htlive.com

MUMBAI: With a huge requirement for rehabilitation housing, the BMC aims to generate between 5,000 and 10,000 Project Affected Persons (PAP) tenements in each administrative zone of the city. Yet, even as it faces this imperative and has committed thousands of crores of rupees towards PAP projects, it is considering releasing 1,802.75 sq metres of land reserved specifically for rehabilitation and resettlement at Majas in Jogeshwari East.

The BMC has approved 34,129 PAP tenements so far. A PAP statement cited in a representation to the civic administration also puts the number of tenements covered by five major projects at 33,332, involving an estimated ₹20,751.67 crore in

PAP housing in Mumbai

34,129
PAP tenements approved by BMC to date as recorded in the 2026-27 budget

33,332
PAP tenements covered by five major projects cited in the representation

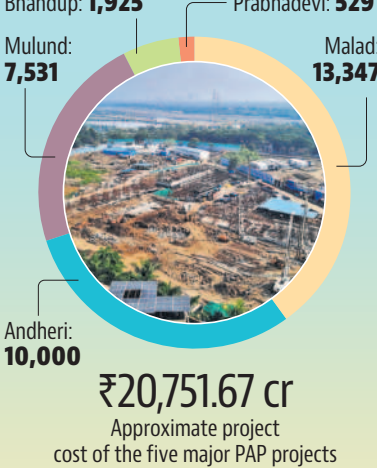
₹4,741.65 cr
Credit notes already issued

5,000-10,000
PAP tenements BMC aims to generate in each administrative zone

₹15,117.81 cr
Approximate total credit notes involved

1,802.75 sq m
Rehabilitation land proposed to be deleted at Majas, Jogeshwari East

PAP SITES BY BMC: 33,342



project costs and around ₹15,117.81 crore in credit notes. Of these, credit notes worth approximately ₹4,741.65 crore have already been issued.

Despite the scale of the requirement, a proposal before the BMC's Improvement Committee seeks to delete the reservation and include the land in

the adjoining residential zone, which has MHADA buildings that need to be redeveloped. Questions have been raised about why a separate parcel reserved for future rehabilitation should be surrendered to facilitate residential development.

The larger plot which encompasses the 1,802.75-sq-metre

rehab component is also a significant public-purpose land resource. Under the earlier Development Plan, it carried reservations for public housing, a bus station, secondary schools, playgrounds, a post office, roads and other amenities. Under DP 2034, it continues to carry several public-pur-

pose reservations and civic facilities, including schools, playgrounds, a police station, BEST bus facility and affordable housing apart from rehabilitation and resettlement.

Ashraf Azmi, Congress group leader in the BMC, demanded that the BMC establish if MHADA redevelopment can occur without sacrificing the rehab reservation or identify equivalent land to replace the loss. He questioned automatically converting the entire 1,802.75-square-metre parcel into a residential zone rather than reserving it for public housing or social infrastructure.

The Congress leader sought details on additional development potential—FSI, TDR, and saleable area—and whether financial premiums would accrue to the BMC. He urged pausing modifications until financial and planning implications are assessed. The timing also raises questions, as MHADA's deletion request came long after 2024 permissions.

Deferred last week, the proposal will soon return to the improvements committee.

2 from city killed in multi-vehicle collision on highway

Shrinivas Deshpande
shrinivas.deshpande@htlive.com

PUNE: Two people were killed and 12 others injured, three of them seriously, in a multi-vehicle accident on the Pune-Bengaluru highway near Jambhulwadi in Ambegaon in the wee hours of Sunday.

The deceased were identified as Hridaynath Mohan Gaikwad (47), a resident of Jogeshwari East, and Anandibai Ramchandra Wadkar (50), a resident of Nerul, Navi Mumbai. Both died while undergoing treatment.

According to Sharad Zine, senior inspector at Ambegaon police station, the accident occurred at 12:10 am near Dari Pool. An Ashok Leyland truck, travelling from Satara towards

Pune, allegedly rammed into the rear of an Eicher truck. "The impact caused both vehicles to veer into the opposite lane, where they collided with a Maruti Suzuki Ertiga and a Tata Altroz travelling towards Satara. The Eicher truck, Ertiga and Altroz were severely damaged," said Zine. Twelve people were injured; three are reported to be in serious condition.

Police cleared the accident site and restored traffic movement.

Police said they took the truck owner, Sandeep Gorakh Suryawanshi (45) from Khataw, into custody while efforts were on to arrest the Ashok Leyland truck driver, Pramod Vitthal Wagh (40), a resident of Khataw taluka in Satara district.



The impact caused both trucks to veer into the opposite lane, where they collided with a Maruti Suzuki Ertiga and a Tata Altroz travelling towards Satara, police said.

{ ASSAULT ON DOCTORS IN PALGHAR }

8 absconding Sena workers surrender



On September 5, the accused allegedly assaulted doctors and staff following a dispute over treatment of Govindas

Pankaj Raut
letters@hindustantimes.com

PALGHAR: Eight Shiv Sena functionaries accused of assaulting doctors and medical staff at a private hospital in Palghar on September 5 surrendered before the Palghar police on Sunday. The driver of one of the eight accused was also arrested during the day.

Late at night on Sunday, all nine accused were produced before the court of the Judicial Magistrate First Class (JMFC) and remanded in police custody till September 16. The court also extended till September 16 the police remand of Shiv Sena city chief Rahul Gharat and 12 govinदा troupe members arrested earlier.

On Friday, the Bombay High Court had rapped the Palghar police over its "most lackadaisical" probe into the assault on doctors and medical staff and directed the Special Inspector General, Konkan division, to review the investigation and submit a report by September 17.

The same day, the investigating officer (IO) in the case was changed for the third time.

While police sub-inspector Vinayak Kesarkar was named IO in the FIR, on September 8, Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO), Palghar Umesh Gawali was made the IO. Subsequently, on September 11, Dahanu SDPO

Nisha Jadhav was named IO in the case.

The case stems from a September 5 incident at Relief Hospital in Palghar, when a group of Shiv Sena functionaries allegedly assaulted doctors and staff following a dispute over treatment and discharge of Govindas injured during Dahi Handi celebrations.

The Palghar police subsequently booked 17 people, including the Shiv Sena Palghar district chief Kundan Sankhe, city chief Rahul Gharat, and deputy taluka chief Rohit Gavit. While the Sena suspended the trio and four other accused functionaries, Gharat surrendered before the police on September 7.

Rohit Gavit, son of MLA Rajendra Gavit, was arrested on September 11 and remanded in police custody till September 16.

Among the eight Sena functionaries who surrendered on Sunday, Manish Sankhe, Rahul Sankhe, Sairaj Patil, Kundan Sankhe, Nilam Sankhe and Shubham Bandiwadkar had applied for anticipatory bail and their hearing was scheduled on September 15.

Two other Sena functionaries who surrendered on Sunday were Manoj Gharat and Vrushab Vare. Apart from them, the police also arrested Sahil Raut, driver of accused Sairaj Patil. The total arrests in the case have now reached 23.



**TEERTHANKER
MAHAVEER UNIVERSITY**
Moradabad

Accredited with NAAC A Grade

12-B Status from UGC

A **dream** envisioned by
Hon'ble Chancellor Shri Suresh Jain,
a legacy built over 25 years.

Celebrating

25th

Foundation Day

of
Teerthanker Mahaveer University*



*The journey began with TMIMT College in 2001, followed by the establishment of TMU in 2008.

Why Thane Ring Metro is raising a storm

Questions centre on alleged design flaws, route redundancies, environmental costs and transparency in the mammoth project that is yet to get off the ground

Kaptaan Mali
letters@hindustantimes.com

THANE: The proposed Thane Integral Ring Metro Rail Project, cleared by the state government in August 2025, has become the subject of intense debate in Thane. Citizens and experts have flagged alleged design flaws, route redundancies, environmental issues and social costs. Most importantly, they say, the government must publish the detailed public report (DPR) for public scrutiny.

One of the top concerns are the 82 bends in the 29-km route, an engineering challenge in a heavily congested city. Thane has extensive underground utility networks, which could make the execution of a project like this very difficult, say activists.

The proposed route passes through densely populated residential, commercial and industrial areas, prompting activists to point to the possible relocation of homes, businesses and informal settlements. The government has acknowledged that the route, from Wagle Estate via Lokmanya Nagar Bus Depot to Upvan, could potentially displace nearly 1,500 families in Lokmanya Nagar.

Also, industrialists at the Upvan Industrial Estate worry that they may have to cede land to the project. Gopal Gurav, secretary of the Pokhran Small Scale Industrial Association, claims more than 40 industrial plots will be impacted by the metro, affecting 500-odd workers. Gurav also says businesses were not adequately consulted before the route was finalised.

The metro's underground section has also raised some red flags. Citizens for Sustainable Transport (CST-Thane), a non-profit, says around 3 km of the proposed route passes beneath the heavily congested Thane railway station area. Extensive excavation work here could disrupt

What's worrying citizens



Residents launched a signature campaign alleging that the Ring Metro project would adversely affect the environment and also compromise the privacy of citizens living in the area.

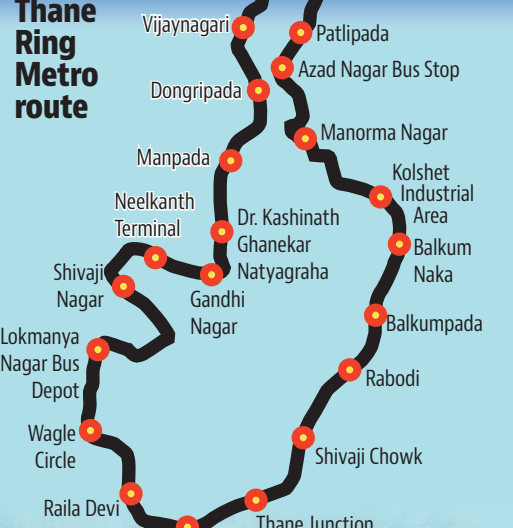
82 Bends along the 29-km route
• Engineering challenges posed by the unusually high number of bends.

647,000 Projected commuters
• Citizens question whether the projected ridership will justify the project.

3,224 Trees marked for felling or transplantation

5times: Activists say the TMC's figure is five times higher than the DPR estimate.

Fast-growing areas left out
• The project does not serve rapidly developing areas such as Kalwa, Mumbra and Diva.



317 trees to face the axe in Yeoor-SGNP



Of these trees, 259 are native species in Yeoor. PRAFUL GANGURDE

Kaptaan Mali
letters@hindustantimes.com

THANE: The proposed ₹12,200-crore Thane Ring Metro project will lead to the uprooting of 317 trees within the eco-sensitive zone of the Yeoor-Sanjay Gandhi National Park (SGNP), including 259 native species, according to a forest official.

The alignment will pass through the eco-sensitive zones of Majiwada, Chital-sar, Manpada, Wagbil and Gaimukh.

Pradeep Patil, deputy director, SGNP, Thane Division, told HT that the project would require forest land between Majiwada and Gaimukh, though the exact requirement within the sensitive zone has not yet been determined. He noted that while eco-sensitive zones

around national parks are generally about 1 km wide elsewhere, the distance in Mumbai and Thane is only 100 metres.

The environmental impact has added to opposition from locals, planners, politicians and NGOs, who have questioned the impact of cutting or transplanting more than 3,100 trees.

Advocate Radhika Prakash Rane, founder of Thane Against Integral Ring Metro, said mature trees support biodiversity, absorb carbon and regulate urban heat, and cannot be replaced by saplings planted elsewhere.

Maha Metro MD Shrawan Hardikar said 500 trees would be cut and 2,600 transplanted.

It plans to plant over 37,000 trees, which will be monitored for seven years.

traffic and commuters for years, they say.

Low ridership

Critics of the metro project are also questioning the need to spend ₹12,500 crore on a project that will serve a projected 647,000 commuters. According to Meghna Shetty, a member of the Wake Up Thanekar non-profit, the project places a large financial burden without delivering proportional benefits.

Some critics allege duplication with existing metro infrastructure. Thane is already served by Metro Line 4, from Wadala to Kasarvadavali, and Metro Line 5, which connects Thane to Bhivandi. Instead, according to architect and urban planner Sulakshana Mahajan, the authorities should address areas that lack adequate public transport.

The proposed Dongripada station is expected to run parallel to an existing Metro Line 4 station on the same road, serving a similar catchment area. Opponents argue that this overlap represents an inefficient use of public funds and does little to address genuine

connectivity gaps within Thane's transport network.

Environmental concerns have added another layer to the debate. While the plan submitted by the Maharashtra Metro Rail Corporation (Maha Metro) states that 662 trees will be affected by the project, activists claim the Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC) Tree Authority has identified 3,224 trees for felling or transplantation, nearly five times the number cited in the report. Critics argue that such discrepancies raise serious questions about the accuracy of the environmental assessment underpinning the project.

Environmentalists also warn that the proposed Waterfront station and related construction activities along Thane's shoreline could adversely affect the ecologically sensitive mangrove ecosystem of the Thane Creek. No comprehensive Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) has been made publicly available.

Alignment flaws

Political opposition has focused on changing the proposed alignment.

BJP MLC Niranjan Davkhare highlighted the absence of Kalwa, Mumbra and Diva from the original metro plan, arguing that these rapidly developing areas should be connected to the wider metro network.

As a result, at a meeting chaired by deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde on August 3, Maha Metro was directed to conduct a public hearing, initiate the process of extending metro connectivity to Kalwa, Mumbra and Diva, and prepare an impact assessment report for areas such as Chendani Koliwada and old Thane.

State transport minister Pratap Sarnaik has suggested that the route run through Wagle Estate, Lokmanya Nagar Bus Depot, Aai Mata Mandir, Runwal Plaza, Vedant, Acharya Atr Marg, Vartak Nagar and Pokhran Road, eventually connecting Pokhran Road No 1 and No 2.

The original Upvan alignment has also been criticised because the area is bordered by the Sanjay Gandhi National Park and Upvan Lake, limiting the possibility of large-scale future development.

According to Mahajan, the ring metro project is more "construction-oriented" than "transport-oriented", with the emphasis appearing to be on creating infrastructure rather than addressing Thane's actual mobility requirements. She pointed out that the project was initially planned as a Bus Rapid Transit System (BRTS) before being converted into a ring metro. Environmental analyst Dr Raman Tekale said a fresh, Thane-specific multimodal transport study was needed to examine bus connectivity, cycling infrastructure, pedestrian mobility and integration with the suburban railway network before committing to another large-scale metro investment.

Maha Metro defends project

Maha Metro managing director Shrawan Hardikar said the organisation would assess the proposed alternatives based on financial implications, relocation requirements and other impacts before submitting its recommendations to the government.

Dismissing technical concerns,

Hardikar said the project would use the New Austrian Tunneling Method (NATM), a "safe" method used in the Pune Metro. It "had not caused even headline fractures" in surrounding structures, he said.

On environmental issues, Hardikar said only 500 trees would be cut and 2,600 transplanted, while Maha Metro plans to plant around 37,000 trees along with the forest department and TMC. Around 60% of the tunnelling debris would be reused for land reclamation and filling at the Kasarvadavali depot.

Regarding the project's finan-

cial structure, Hardikar said 20% of the cost would be funded by the central government, 20% by the Maharashtra government and 60% through international lenders such as KfW and the Asian Development Bank. The TMC would be responsible for land acquisition and management of project-affected persons.

The project is currently undergoing a geotechnical survey, while land acquisition by the depot at Kasarvadavali is 40% complete. Hardikar said an environmental study assessing the impact on SGNP and surrounding forests is also underway.

BID TO MONETISE NASHIK RING RD LAND BEFORE ACQUIRING LAND

Yogesh Naik
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: With land acquisition for the Nashik ring road still underway, the Maharashtra State Infrastructure Development Corporation (MSIDC) has initiated efforts to monetise land along the proposed road which is being constructed for the Kumbh Mela next year, officials familiar with the matter told Hindustan Times.

Ranjit Hande, chief engineer, MSIDC said the ring road would comprise six lanes and the right of way would be 60 metres, along the lines of the ring road constructed for the Kumbh Mela in Prayagraj.

"We are yet to acquire the land fully. But we are appointing a consultant to get ideas on how to monetise land along the road," Hande said. The proposed road spans 66 km and 386 hectares of land needs to be acquired for it, he stated, adding, "We are now checking how much more land needs to be acquired for monetisation and facilities like hotels and ancillary activities."

Local residents and activists have raised concerns over the ring road, calling it unnecessary and a ploy by politicians and bureaucrats to grab villagers' land.

Activist Karan Gaikar of Chhava Krantiveer Sena alleged the people who were finalising the alignment of the ring road were also buying land along the route. "The work order for construction of the ring road must be issued only when 55% land is acquired. But as of now, only 14% land has been acquired," he said.

Gaikar further alleged that while the authorities claim that four houses will need to be demolished along a 12-km stretch, the actual number of affected properties was far higher.

"In reality, at least 40 houses will be affected, and 25 wells, 13 borewells and 16 polyhouses will have to be acquired," he said. "The alignment is being planned in such a way that government officers, politicians and builders whose land is along the route will stand to benefit."

**Thane Municipal Corporation, Thane**
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
TENDER NOTICE

Online tenders are hereby invited for the following work under the budget head "Special Provision for Development of Basic Amenities in the Municipal Corporation Area" for the year 2026-27 (Account Head No. 221170913): for the work "Development of the plot and execution of permissible civil works for the Solid Waste Management Project of Thane Municipal Corporation at Mouje Atkoli (Phase - 4)." Participation in this tender will be prohibited for those tenderers against whom penal action of debarred has been taken/ initiated by any Government/Semi Government / Public Sector under taking / urban local body/ municipal corporation etc. The blank tender forms and the detailed information regarding proposal would be available on www.mahatenders.gov.in from dt.15.09.2026 to dt. 22.09.2026 up to 16.00 hrs. Online tenders shall be received on or before dt. 22.09.2026 up to 16.00 hrs. and will be opened on dt. 24.09.2026 at 16.30 hrs if possible in the presence of the willing bidders or their representative.

TMC/PRO/PWD/522/2026-27
SD/-
Dt.11.09.2026
Executive Engineer,
pls visit our official web-site Thane Municipal Corporation
www.thanecity.gov.in

WESTERN RAILWAY
VARIOUS WORKS

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (Coaching) Mumbai Central-08, invites
Sr. No.1. E-tender Notice No: WR-MMCTOEOCA (ECTD)/5/2026R O/o SRDEE/CHG/MMCT/W/R (Computer No.720105). Name of Work: Annual Maintenance Contract of AC package unit of various make fitted on LHB type and SGAC coaches of roof mounted design of Bandra Terminus coaching depot of Mumbai Division for a period of ONE year. **Approx. cost of Work:** ₹ 6,35,98,097.24. **Bid Security:** ₹ 12,72,000/-. **Sr. No.2. E-tender Notice No: WR-MMCTOEOCA (ECTD)/4/3/2026 O/o SRDEE/CHG/MMCT/W/R (Computer No.781010). Name of Work:** Provision, installation, testing, commissioning of 200 VA, 750/415 V Control transformers in DA set switchgear panel in LHB power car of Mumbai Division. **Approx. cost of Work:** ₹ 4,72,292.64. **Bid Security:** ₹ 9,500/-. **Date and Time of Submission of both Tenders:** Till 05.10.2026, 15:00 hrs. **Date & Time Opening of both Tenders:** On 05.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs. For further details please visit our website www.irps.gov.in

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly)

WESTERN RAILWAY
TELECOM INFRA WORKS

Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer (North), 2nd Floor, Divisional Railway Manager Office, Mumbai Central, Mumbai-400 008, invites **E-Tender No: SC-216-2-159-WA-PH-32-53 dated 09/09/2026. Work and Location:** Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning, Integration of Telecom systems including trenching, HDD, jointing, cable laying, ducting, cable termination, networking for various works associated with extension of middle Foot Over Bridge to west side at Valsad, providing new Foot Over Bridge at North end (On Valsad, new waiting hall/room at Vapi, renovation of east booking office at Vapi, CCTV at sensitive locations such as Non-Interlocked Level Crossing (NI LC) Gates, etc. **Cost of Work:** ₹ 1,94,92,069.03. **EMD:** ₹ 3,89,900/-. **Date & Time for closure for Submission of E-Tender Documents:** Till 06.10.2026, 15:00 hrs. **Date & Time for Opening of E-Tender:** On 06.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs. The tender can be viewed at website www.irps.gov.in

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly)

WESTERN RAILWAY
DEVELOPMENT OF CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE FOR RMPU OVERHAULING CUM PULL-DOWN TEST FACILITIES

Divisional Railway Manager(WA), Western Railway, 6th floor, Engg. Deptt., Mumbai Central, Mumbai-400 008, invites **E-Tender Notice No: BCT/26-27/148 dt.10/09/2026. Work and Location:** Pull-down (Carriage repair workshop) - Development of Centre of Excellence for RMPU overhauling cum Pull-down Test facilities in Carriage Repair Workshop. (Composite Tender). **Approx. Cost of Work:** ₹ 6,13,26,256.06. **EMD:** ₹ 10,26,500/-. **Date & Time of Submission:** Till 06.10.2026, 15:00 hrs. **Date & Time of Opening:** On 06.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs. For further details please visit our website www.irps.gov.in

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly)

PUBLIC NOTICE
INTRODUCTION OF AC 25 KV TRACTION WARNING TO UNAUTHORIZED PERSON

Notice is hereby given to all users of Railway lines and premises situated on the completed section of the under noted section of Mumbai division of Western Railway that the 25000 Volts, 50 cycles AC overhead traction wires will be energized on or after the date specified against the section. On and from the same date the overhead traction line shall be treated as live at all times and no unauthorized person shall approach or work in the proximity of the said overhead line.

Section	Date
Line between Mahabli EMU workshop and DNL near Lower Parel Station between Km 7/8A and 7/11D.	25.09.2026

**WESTERN RAILWAY**
www.indianrailways.gov.in
0593

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly) | [X.com/WesternRly](https://www.x.com/WesternRly)

WESTERN RAILWAY
STRUCTURAL REPAIR AND PAINTING WORKS

Divisional Railway Manager (WA), Western Railway Mumbai Central, Mumbai-400008, invites **E-Tender Notice No: BCT/26-27/149 dt. 10/09/2026. Work and Location:** CL-BP - Structural repair and painting of B, C, D, G, H, K, N, M, P block, Imperial mansion, East Villa, Club, Badminton Hall, Squash court and other service buildings. **Approx. Cost of Work:** ₹ 3,37,58,634/- **EMD:** ₹ 6,75,200/- **Date & Time of Submission:** Till 06.10.2026, 15:00 hrs. **Date & Time of Opening:** On 06.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs. For further details please visit our website www.irps.gov.in. Manual offers will not be considered.

Like us on: [facebook.com/WesternRly](https://www.facebook.com/WesternRly)

PUNJAB STATE WAREHOUSING CORPORATION, CHANDIGARH
SCO 74-75, BANK SQUARE, SECTOR-17B, CHANDIGARH
E-mail: etopswc@punjab.gov.in

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
TENDER NO.: PSWC/CTO/2026-27/07

Punjab State Warehousing Corporation invites online bids for Selection of Cloud Service Provider for Punjab State Warehousing Corporation.

Closing date and time : 29.09.2026 at 3.00 pm
For details log on to : <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>
Note: Any addendum(s)/Corrigendum(s) to the Tender Notice shall be published on the above website only.

Sd/-
Managing Director

RO NO. 1004/12/2026/27/15090

**Classifieds**
Monday
www.htclassifieds.com

MISCELLANEOUS

CHANGE OF NAME

I HEREBY state that my name is Babu Lankalapalli Padmaraj S/o Late Lankalapalli Rammoohan Rao, residing at Kharghar, Navi Mumbai. My name printed in various Naval Documents including Pension Payment Order, appears as Lankakullu Babu Padmaraj. The same may be aligned with Babu Lankalapalli Padmaraj, wherever it is printed as Lankakullu Babu Padmaraj. I hereby also state that wherever it is printed as Lankalapalli Babu Padmaraj, Babu Lankalapalli Padmaraj, Padmaraj Babu Lankalapalli, Babu L. Padmaraj, B.L. Padmaraj and L.B. Padmaraj are all names belonging to one and the same person and that is me. This is as per affidavit no. 346012026 sworn before notary Ms. Sujata J. Patil dated 27/08/2026 at Navi Mumbai.

For

Advertisement

Call

Manish Shirke

9820748750

Readers are recommended to make all enquiries and seek appropriate advice before acting on any advertisement appearing in this publication. Any subscriber sending money, incurring any expenses or acting on any medical recommendations or entering into any commitment in relation to any advertisement published in this publication, shall do so entirely at his/her discretion, intelligence and risk. The Company, Publisher or any of its employees do not vouch for any claims made by the Advertisers of products and services and shall not be held liable for any damages, loss, consequences, suffered by any person on account of relying on such advertisements.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

**TWTW**
THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



SPOTLIGHT BRICS 2026

China will lead creation of open source AI for Brics: Xi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Russian President Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the 18th Brics Summit in New Delhi.

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: China will lead the creation of an open source artificial intelligence (AI) with an open eco-system for the Brics grouping, President Xi Jinping said on Sunday against the backdrop of intense competition between Beijing and Washington in the sector.

The AI initiative was among five trade and technology related proposals unveiled by Xi at the outreach session of the Brics Summit focused on resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability. He also proposed a trade and investment facilitation initiative, digital industry cooperation initiative, intelligent manufacturing cooperation initiative and science and technology talent initiative.

The AI proposal follows China's creation of the World AI Cooperation Organisation, a group of some 30 countries. China is working to build an AI ecosystem that provides domestic and international users with lower cost alternatives to US technology. China's approach contrasts with the closed model

approaches of key American developers such as OpenAI and Anthropic. Listing his proposal for open source and inclusive AI, Xi said: "China will be a pioneer in establishing a Brics AI open source community, support cooperation in developing and applying large language models, hold specialised AI seminars and training courses, and build an open ecosystem for AI."

While addressing the main session of the Brics Summit on Saturday, Xi had proposed the "Brics Initiative on Artificial Intelligence Empowering New Industrialisation" and said China will work with other countries to deepen cooperation in industrial and supply chains.

As part of the trade and investment facilitation initiative, Xi said China will establish a Brics special economic zone partnership, under which countries can set up an intelligent portal, coordinate policies and build a "new frontier for open development". China will also hold the Brics Forum on Trade in Services next year to advance new drivers of economic and trade cooperation.

Xi's proposal for a digital

industry cooperation initiative envisages the creation of a Brics digital ecosystem cloud platform, and digital skills training, technological exchange and industrial alignment to jointly develop the digital economy.

Under the intelligent manufacturing cooperation initiative, China will assist Brics states to build smart factories and develop standards and norms, while jointly promoting manufacturing transformation and upgrading. The science and technology talent development initiative will comprise a Brics engineer cultivation alliance for development of engineers and mutual recognition of standards, Xi said.

Xi pointed to changes accelerating around the world and the Global South becoming a key driver of multipolarity at a time when the global landscape is "volatile and fraught with risks and challenges". Brics countries must rally the Global South and become a stabilising force to bring stability to the world, he said. "...Fairness and justice is a universal aspiration, and international rules must be written by all countries," Xi said.

Putin proposes new insurance system and grain market for Brics

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Russia on Sunday proposed a new insurance mechanism and a collaborative initiative for the grain market for Brics member states, with President Vladimir Putin urging the grouping to adopt a holistic approach towards pressing global challenges.

Putin proposed the initiatives as the Brics member states and partner countries came together for an outreach session at the concluding day of the Brics Summit hosted by India against the backdrop of wide-ranging sanctions imposed by the West on Russia for the invasion of Ukraine. "We have independent routes for moving capital, labour and technologies. In fact, we can operate regardless of outside pressure," Putin said. "We have some promising initiatives, such as creating an insurance mechanism and a grain market. These are Russian proposals, and we invite all other member states to make use of those."

The proposals came against the backdrop of the European Union (EU), the G7 and Britain prohibiting Western companies from insuring any merchant vessel transporting Russian energy unless the oil is purchased at below a specified price cap. Widening sanctions on the insurance sector have already hit Russian crude exports.

Putin complimented the functioning of the New Development Bank, a multilateral development bank established by Brics



The broad participation in today's meeting confirms that international interest in Brics continues to grow

VLADIMIR PUTIN,
Russian President

states that is handling projects worth \$140 billion, as he backed a "holistic approach" towards international challenges.

"As global challenges keep surfacing, we should adopt a holistic approach to address both the symptoms and root causes," he said.

"Global South countries should jointly advance better [global] governance structure and tackle both traditional and non-traditional security threats."

He contended that the global stature of Brics is on the rise because of the bloc's focus on charting an independent course to combat global challenges. "The broad participation in today's meeting confirms that international interest in Brics continues to grow. Many around the world find our core values and ideals appealing, including our commitment to charting an independent course and a desire to resolve problems collectively, guided by international law and key provisions of the UN Charter," he said.



(Clockwise from top) Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Philippines' President Bongbong Marcos; South African President Cyril Ramaphosa; Uganda's Vice President Jessica Alupo; and Kazakhstan President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev at Bharat Mandapam on Sunday.

PMO

{ SUMMIT SIDELINES }

PM's bilateral talks put security, trade in focus

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Philippines President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr agreed to expand cooperation in defence, security, trade and investment during a meeting on the margins of the Brics Summit on Sunday.

The Philippines participated in the summit as the current chair of Asean, providing an opportunity for the two leaders to review bilateral ties. The Philippines is a key partner for India in the Asean grouping and shared concerns over China's actions across the region have fostered closer strategic and security cooperation between the two countries.

The leaders expressed satisfaction at progress in bilateral cooperation across all areas and agreed to deepen and expand collaboration in defence, security, trade, investment, space, railway infrastructure, fintech, education, tourism, technology, and people-to-people ties, the external affairs ministry said in a readout.

Modi and Marcos also discussed regional and global issues and reiterated their commitment to strengthen cooperation across all areas of the bilateral strategic partnership.

"We reviewed the growing momentum in the India-Philippines strategic partnership," Modi said on social media, adding that focus areas in the discussions included economic linkages, technology, trade and

space.

Modi held a separate meeting with South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and reviewed cooperation in diverse areas. They also exchanged views on global issues and agreed to maintain close coordination at multilateral forums, the ministry said.

Modi said on social media that he and Ramaphosa reviewed the India-South Africa strategic partnership, including the India-SACU trade agreement, mining and critical minerals, infrastructure, food security, digital public infrastructure and emerging technologies. "We will work closely for Africa's progress, the priorities of the Global South and a more balanced global order," Modi said.

Modi also held meetings with Kazakh President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, Ugandan vice president Jessica Rose Epel Alupo, Nigerian vice president Kashim Shettima Mustapha, Burundi President Evariste Ndayishimiye, who is also chairperson of the African Union, and reviewed bilateral ties.

Modi and Tokayev reviewed bilateral cooperation in trade, defence, security, connectivity, energy, critical minerals and emerging technologies, and exchanged perspectives on regional and international developments.

They agreed to strengthen the bilateral strategic partnership for peace, stability and development in the region.

Modi and Alupo reviewed

ties between India and Uganda and emphasised the need to enhance cooperation in priority areas through technology partnerships, investment facilitation, and private sector collaboration. They also called for closer bilateral engagement to champion the voice of the Global South.

Modi and Mustapha reviewed the India-Nigeria relationship and discussions focussed on key areas such as trade, investment, defence, energy partnership, agriculture, health and digital technologies. Modi and Mustapha also discussed regional and global matters, including priorities and concerns of the Global South.

They emphasised the importance of strengthening cooperation in multilateral forums and working together for a more representative, inclusive and multipolar global order. Modi highlighted India's commitment to deepen engagement with Africa, and Mustapha appreciated India's contribution to capacity building and economic development in Nigeria.

Modi and Ndayishimiye stressed that the India-African Union partnership is a key pillar of cooperation within the Global South. They discussed the early convening of the India-Africa Forum Summit.

Modi commended the African Union leadership for combating the Ebola outbreak, and Ndayishimiye appreciated New Delhi's medical support to Africa CDC to help in mitigating the outbreak.



Antonio Guterres

'MASSIVE GLOBAL SUPPORT NEEDED FOR DEVELOPING NATIONS SDGs'

Jasjeev Gandhik

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: United Nations Secretary General Antonio Guterres on Sunday acknowledged that developing countries around the world needed "massive international support" to be able to implement their sustainable development goals (SDGs), as he called for multilateral development banks to look at new business models to mobilise private investment and concessional funding for developing countries.

Speaking on the second and final day of the Brics Summit, Guterres stressed that the 1.5°Celsius will be surpassed soon and asked for the overshoot to be made as small and short as possible, by "over-delivering" on national climate plans, while focusing on climate justice. He also stressed on the need for world peace.

"International financial architecture must be reformed giving higher participation and influence to developing in the decision-making processes in order to guarantee more equity and justice, and to address historical injustices..." Guterres said, calling for countries to work towards development-oriented debt architecture and effective debt relief mechanisms.

"Scientists confirm we will soon breach the 1.5 degree limit. We must make this overshoot as small and short as possible. We need an overshoot of ambition: accelerating the transition from fossil fuels to renewables, slashing methane, protecting nature," he said.

On global conflicts, Guterres said, "From Gaza, to the broader crisis in the Middle East, to Ukraine, Sudan and beyond, our world needs peace. As we move irreversibly to a multipolar world, all countries must work to strengthen and safeguard a multilateral system that delivers for all with UN at its centre."

Leaders hail Brics CONNECT initiative

Pallavi Singhal and Sanjay Maurya

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Brics countries have committed to strengthening collaboration in "forecasting skills needs" by analysing labour market trends in digital, green, care and other priority sectors, as the 11-nation grouping of major emerging market economies welcomed "Brics CONNECT", a new platform for technical cooperation, knowledge exchange and capacity building.

The New Delhi Declaration, adopted by Brics leaders on Saturday, said member countries recognised "the transformative role of digital technologies in expanding the outreach of social protection and enhancing inclusiveness and accessibility for workers' welfare". It also called for exploring "innovative, nation-

ally tailored policy approaches to increase social protection coverage to workers in the gig and platform economy".

The declaration welcomed Brics CONNECT (Brics Cooperation Network for Capacity Building, Employability, and New Skills and Technologies), adopted on July 15 as part of the Brics labour and employment ministers' declaration in Hyderabad. The platform will facilitate exchange of policies and technologies on jobs, skills and social security, with gig and platform workers among its areas of cooperation. Brics CONNECT is aligned with four priority areas: advancing social security, enhancing female labour force participation, cooperating on employability and skills mapping, and leveraging technology for workers' well-being. It will complement the existing Brics Virtual

Liaison Office, an online platform for cooperation and knowledge-sharing on social security.

The declaration also noted a proposal to establish capacity-building centres for Brics member states to help create a "future-ready workforce". Countries committed for "forecasting skills needs" in various sectors and ensuring "alignment of training programmes with evolving market demands" and promoting "linkage of TVET institutions with industries".

Experts, however, said India needs stronger systems to identify skill gaps and prepare workers for changing labour markets.

Prof Santosh Mehrotra, Research Fellow at the IZA Institute of Labour Economics, Luxembourg, and former economics professor at JNU, said India has faced "close to half a century" of neglect of skilling and vocational

education, alongside inadequate school education. He said only around 4% of India's workforce has received formal technical and vocational education and training (TVET), compared with about 80% in China.

"First, India needs to learn how to do skill-gap analysis. Secondly, it needs to work on improving skills for existing job sectors..." Mehrotra said. "In Germany or in China, vocational and technical education training has an aspirational element that does not exist in India," he said.

Dr Harshil Sharma, who holds a PhD in labour economics from JNU said the Brics commitment was welcome but needed stronger industry participation.

"Industry linkage only works when employers set assessment standards and absorb apprentices, not when they sit on advisory boards," he said.

From PM museum to Indian accent, leaders' spouses explore Delhi

Hemani Bhandari

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: From lunch at Bukhara, ITC Maurya, to Indian Accent at The Lodhi and shopping at Khan Market, spouses of Brics participants, heads of state and accompanying delegates explored some of Delhi's prominent restaurants, markets, museums and heritage sites on the second day of the grouping's summit, officials aware of the matter said.

The movement plan prepared for the visiting delegations included visits to several prominent locations, with different groups following separate itineraries.

Angeline Ndayishimiye, wife of Burundi's president Evariste Ndayishimiye visited Ambience Mall in Vasant Kunj, while another Burundi delegation visited DLF Emporio, a senior official said. The Philippines delegation had lunch at Taj Man Singh, while a delegation was taken to Bukhara at ITC Maurya.

"Important attendees from Iran visited Indian Accent at The Lodhi Hotel, while another Iranian group visited the Brics Bazaar and Prime Minister Sangrahalya," the officer said.

Members of the South Africa delegation visited Khan Market, one of the national capital's upscale shopping and dining hubs.

The Brics Bazaar, where products and cultural items from participating countries were displayed, was visited by delegates from different participating countries.

The visiting groups were also taken to cultural and heritage destinations, the officer said. "The Philippines delegation visited the PM Sangrahalya", while the National Gallery of Modern Art was on the itinerary of a delegation who the officer refused to name.

The heads of nations on Sunday visited Akshardham and Humayun's Tomb, and G20 Park on Kautilya Marg were also included in the movement plan, a second official said.

Security were stepped up at multiple venues spread across south, central and central-south Delhi. "The movement of the delegates and family members was planned in advance, with security arrangements at every venue and along the routes. Our focus was to ensure seamless movement while keeping the impact on regular traffic to a minimum," the officer said.

Congress, BJP trade barbs over all-vegetarian fare for dignitaries

Saubhadra Chatterji

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: As the two-day Brics Summit came to an end on Sunday, a political tussle began between the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) with the Opposition party accusing the BJP of imposing its dietary preference and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi pointed out that 80% of Indians are non-vegetarians, after an all-vegetarian fare was served for international leaders at New Delhi's Bharat Mandapam.

"The BJP's habit of imposing its dietary preferences on fellow Indians is deeply problematic. Now, they have taken it a step further by imposing their own choices on dignitaries from across the world," Congress leader Pawan Khera said in a post on X.

"India is a rich, diverse, multi-cuisine country, home to some of the finest non-vegetarian delicacies that people across the world relish and enjoy. So why did the Modi government choose to hide this part of India's culture? Is it ashamed of the diversity that makes India what it is?" Khera added.

Rahul Gandhi posted a picture of Chhole Bhature—one of



Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Malaysia's Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim and Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra during a breakfast meeting in New Delhi.

AICC

Delhi's popular snacks—and said, "For the record: 80% of Indians are non-vegetarian. Indian non-vegetarian food is delicious. As are my sister's chole bhature."

Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Mahua Moitra suggested the international dignitaries to go to Karim's. "Would I be a bad MP if I advised the visiting Brics leaders to give this menu a miss & get security to nip down to the nearest Karims & bring back some Burrab Kababs," she said in a post on X.

To be sure, this is not the first time the government arranged a full vegetarian spread for heads of states and other important

leaders. During the G20 meeting in Delhi, the food at both Bharat Mandapam and the President's banquet was fully vegetarian, showcasing India's culinary diversity.

BJP MP Sambit Patra hit back at the Congress and quipped that some Opposition members and the Congress are suffering from indigestion. "Today, some people—certain opposition members and the Congress Party—are suffering from indigestion because India is surging ahead. Remember, the 'I' in Brics stands for India, and that 'I' represents 1.4 billion people. I am India. I am one of the strongest partners of Brics, and I am proud of it."

Member nations vow crackdown on digital 'scam compounds'

Sejal Sharma

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Declaration issued by Brics leaders addressed the two increasingly urgent issues for the member states—the rise of organised digital fraud operations and the need for coordinated rules around AI.

The declaration, unanimously adopted by the 11 member countries of the bloc on Saturday, expressed serious concern over the proliferation of organised scam networks, specifically citing cross-border operations and alleged "scam compounds" that exploit digital technologies, payment systems, and vulnerable individuals.

The declaration calls for stronger cooperation between customs authorities, financial intelligence units, law enforcement agencies, tax authorities, and supervisory bodies. Telecommunications providers and technology platforms are also being asked to improve information-sharing and adopt data analytics to help detect and disrupt money laundering schemes.

On payments infrastructure, leaders reiterated that there is "no one-size-fits-all approach" to

settling trade in local currencies, signalling that broader efforts to reduce reliance on the US dollar remain at an early, exploratory stage.

Sandeep K Shukla, cybersecurity expert and director at IIIT Hyderabad, said that while the declaration flagged cyber fraud, scam compounds in Southeast Asia, cross-border cybercrime, and called for cooperation between Brics countries through CERTs, financial intelligence units and law enforcement agencies, the cooperation on these matters is not binding and rather a show of requirements to solve transnational crimes.

"It [declaration] also encouraged countries to sign the UN treaty on cybercrime but interestingly India is yet to sign the treaty whereas 70+ countries have signed. Privacy related laws is an issue that is flagged as a hindrance to full fledged cooperation especially sharing of PII information. In any case, from what I read, the declaration seems to acknowledge that cyber crime across various borders are problematic and hard to investigate without cooperation but does not go far enough to chart any roadmap on how to overcome such hindrances," he said.



OPINION

The
Hindustan Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Post Iran war, oil is the new oil

While the Trump regime could continue with its bravado, some West Asian countries are showing signs of looking for some sort of détente

When the West Asia war started in February and Iran subsequently shut traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, analysts described it as the biggest ever oil shock in the history of capitalism. Oil prices did not support the doomsday predictions. Even in nominal terms, oil barely touched \$120 per barrel (it had been higher when the Russia-Ukraine war broke out in 2022) and, in real terms, prices were well below the historic peaks.

In hindsight, we know why this happened. China curtailed its oil purchases and drew down from its strategic reserves. That buffer is unlikely to cushion energy markets today. And the supply-side shock has increased significantly with Iran-backed rebels in Yemen taking control of the Red Sea Corridor and allegedly destroying the East-West pipeline in Saudi Arabia, both of which are crucial networks to ship Saudi oil if Hormuz remains shut. Oil prices have surged significantly in the last two weeks and could go even higher if these chokes are not eased.

Unless there is a meaningful resolution of the situation in West Asia, the oil shock to global markets is here to stay and will only accentuate. Countries, rich and poor, oil-importing or exporting, contrary to what Donald Trump believes, will pay the price. Fuel prices have gone to a record high in the US ahead of the crucial mid-term elections. India is yet to hike fuel prices, but the buffer against not doing so might wear out soon.

What will it take to solve the problem? Right now, what is happening is a war of attrition between the global energy markets and Iran's ability to survive the costs of war, sanctions, and its squeezed oil revenues, thanks to the US naval blockade. While the Trump administration could continue with its bravado — there hardly seems to be a strategy here — countries in West Asia are beginning to show signs of looking for some sort of détente on their own.

The discussions between Iran's president and UAE's leadership on the sidelines of the BRICS summit and a proposed meeting of West Asian countries at Oman's initiative are some such signs. Such efforts have been catalysed by otherwise absurd fallouts such as Qatar having to buy gas from the US to fulfil its supply obligations. Any such solution, if it were to emerge, will be a welcome development for energy markets, and an ominous sign for the US in the region.

BRICS uses a unity-in-diversity template

‘Concordia res parvae crescunt, discordia maximae dilabuntur,’ said Sallust, the renowned Latin historian and one of the political partisans of Julius Caesar. What was achieved in New Delhi on an overcast September afternoon manifests the quote appropriately: Through harmony, small things grow; through discord, the greatest fall. The BRICS declaration adopted on September 12 by the member nations, often seen as a motley group without common goals, has hushed critics for the time being. Despite internal differences, BRICS+ nations have reached consensus on various substantive issues, expressing an earnest wish to uphold the status quo. By jointly condemning acts of terror, unilateral tax and tariff decisions and ongoing military conflicts; advocating for ease of trade relations among member States; and, most importantly, unequivocally supporting the rights of Palestinians, BRICS has shown that it has, indeed, understood that differences can be set aside to rally behind common causes. The bilateral meeting between the UAE and Iran, despite the two exchanging fire across borders, should be seen as an unexpected bonus.

All eyes were on China's President Xi Jinping as he visited India after seven years, the first time since the Ladakh standoff between the Indian and Chinese armies. In both his bilateral meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his address, Xi belied the perception in some quarters that China merely sees the grouping as a platform for challenging American hegemony. Whether BRICS will be successful in leveraging this growing concord to achieve conflict resolution through dialogue within the grouping, and advocate for the same globally, remains to be seen. For now, let this grouping have its cake and eat it, too: Stay diverse yet united.

The West cannot go on criticising BRICS

Whether BRICS can become a “threat” to the order defined by the West is a question that the Global South should refuse to engage with on the grounds of the continuing condescension of the West

BRICS has come of age, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in his address at the 18th summit of the grouping, hosted in New Delhi over the weekend. It is indeed time for the 20-year-old multilateral platform to be evaluated in terms of how its aspirations have translated into outcomes, and, at a larger level, what the grouping represents and what it has achieved as a cohort.

With a grouping as fractured as BRICS, it is naïve to expect a comprehensive consensus on all things, either in letter or in spirit. Then, why have a grouping at all, or bother with summits, goes the argument. The short answer is: In an era of forever wars and interconnectedness of global supply chains, any consensus is better than no consensus, and any summit or meeting is better than no dialogue. The detailed answer must first examine what the present holds

for the Global South, represented by BRICS member countries.

As Modi observed in his address, the Global South has long been in the back row of decision-making while occupying the front row of consequences. Whether BRICS can change that isn't as important as the question about the West's ability to continue to hold the aegis of the global rules-based order. With the ever-growing inconsistency of the US foreign policy, exacerbated by the second Trump presidency's interventions in Latin America and West Asia, there is a palpable sense of impending doom among the votaries of the 1945 consensus. A diminished United Nations stands as an exhibit of toothless institutional internationalism. What avenue does the Global South, after all, have for its concerns not only to be heard but also mitigated?

It is easy for the West to now undermine globalisation and pivot to more inward-focused domestic and foreign policies, and, consequently, diss multilateralism, once all the gains have been reaped. There is something deeply hypocritical about anti-immigrant rhetoric and policies, speeches on carbon emissions, and even economic sanctions from the West, while the Global South continues to reel under the impact of the former's actions from just a few decades ago. Nepal continues to get billed, as seen in the recent flash floods, for the global environmental changes. India has controlled its carbon emissions despite growing needs, and its solar generation capac-

ity, at 180 terawatt-hours (TWh), is already more than half of that of the US. China's solar power generation is at nearly 1,175 TWh, double the generation in all the G7 countries taken together. The West, in short, must see the limits of its pontifications on peace, sustainability, and development.

BRICS, on the other hand, ought to persist in setting bigger and more ambitious agendas for the Global South. The main summit and the parallel sessions have been allowing space to the member-nations to align their common goals. Beyond the big ticket bilateral meets, it is these negotiations between the public and the private players that confer substance to a grouping such as BRICS. During the 2026 summit, for example, Russia's State-run nuclear energy corporation Rosatom offered Indian firms cutting edge nuclear solutions, bolstering the Russia-India nuclear energy agreement dating back to 1988. This is how cooperation manifests itself materially in summits. While the 1988 agreement resulted in the Kudankulam project, a continued partnership allows it to be sustained meaningfully for both countries.

It now has become fashionable to dismiss BRICS owing to the C-word (conflict). It is true that some member-nations such as India-China and Iran-UAE have engaged in military conflict along international borders. Is conflict resolution served better by a common table where disagreements have at least a chance to be discussed, or by condemning the very table as not



As long as the Global South continues to define “order” and “rules” using a Western vocabulary, no grouping is likely to be deemed satisfactory.

being architecturally perfect? Today, NATO has wider internal fault lines than ever, and the dismissiveness of the US, the chief contributor, has reversed the disarmament trend in Europe. The NATO example has two important lessons for BRICS. First, any one member's untrammelled dominance is bound to result in regional complications in the long run. Second, the confidence with which even a fractured NATO operates is something BRICS ought to emulate. In the last decade, BRICS was seen as a security challenge to the EU on account of its improving coherence and institutionalisation. The setting up of the New Development Bank and the Contingent Reserve Arrangement in 2015 showed how military blocs are not the only way to exert geopolitical influence. The BRICS membership should encourage countries to strive towards achieving common goals and overcome differences. The series of high-level meetings between India and China to resolve their boundary differences in the run-up to this year's summit are clearly not coincidental.

Internal differences may or may not get resolved, but the jointness of BRICS certainly allows member-States

to flag issues that can be collectively worked upon. For example, Modi proposed the need for seafarers' emergency support network as one of the key elements in the BRICS road map in the presence of a powerful group of maritime actors sitting astride crucial global trade choke-points. As observed during the ongoing West Asia conflict, Indian seafarers are disproportionately impacted, primarily owing to their great numbers, and mechanisms ought to be in place to maximise their safety.

It is essential to analyse BRICS pragmatically, but a West-influenced lens cannot do that job either effectively or honestly. As long as the Global South continues to define “order” and “rules” using a Western vocabulary, no grouping is likely to be deemed satisfactory even within the region.

At the same time, whether a more consolidated and cohesive BRICS can become an effective “threat” or “alternative” to the order defined by the West is a question that the Global South should refuse to engage with on the grounds of the continuing condescension of the West.

The views expressed are personal

{ GRAND STRATEGY }

Happymon Jacob



Don't mistake the noise around BRICS for impact

The 2026 Delhi summit of BRICS has been under a spotlight this weekend, and things under a spotlight tend to look bigger and brighter than they actually are. Eleven members, a dozen invitees, Chinese President Xi Jinping visiting India after seven years, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian sharing a table with crown prince of Abu Dhabi — this assembly of heavy weights in a world in turmoil has once again generated speculations that it could emerge as a counter pole to the US. The media commentary has generally tended to portray the summit as a moment of great geopolitical consequence. In reality, the summit is far more modest, and the Indian agenda, quite realistically, reflects that.

What does BRICS do? Mostly, it is a messaging platform. Countries use it to signal mainly to the US and the West. Where a member can negotiate with Washington, it negotiates, bilaterally and quietly. Where it does not agree, cannot agree, or will not agree, it comes to a forum like BRICS and makes a polemical statement.

They do have rhetorical value. But, they do not have much material value, because such statements, of which we find plenty in BRICS declarations over the years, are not backed by rules, force, or any consequence for the country it is aimed at.

The grouping gives leaders who do not otherwise meet much, a place to talk about the world, in the main forum and on the sidelines. Views get exchanged and, sometimes, conflicts get managed, and hard security conversations take place. But on the margins. And they are helpful.

But that doesn't make it an alternative pole that will recast global governance, push back against the US-led order, or produce a currency to rival the dollar. A grouping whose foreign ministers could not manage a joint statement on the Iran war is unlikely to emerge as a pole.

Do they actually, together, want to create a counter pole to the US? India wants to work with the US, with US President Donald Trump or without him. China wants a mutually beneficial economic relationship, and Xi will be in the US for a summit with Trump later this month. While Russia has the most reason to break with the US-led order, Moscow spent this month hosting Trump's envoys, and may hate a China-led order as much as it hates the US-led order.

BRICS, at best, is a pressure group. Its members are inside the US-led order, despite their varying degrees of disagreements with it, and they use the grouping to put pressure on the US for their individual gains — rhetoric in public and negotiations in private. It also does not qualify to a lobby. A lobby argues for its members. BRICS members do not argue for one another; they argue for themselves.

It doesn't address the security concerns of its members either. The reason behind its non-security identity is because of how the grouping came about. NATO, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, and Quad were set up with security being a part of their purpose, albeit in differing degrees. BRICS, on the other

hand, began as an investment bank's acronym for four large emerging economies, and the four governments picked it up, meeting first over lunch on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in 2006 and holding a first summit in 2009 in the wake of the financial crisis. Economic weight, not security, was the criterion for membership. The grouping has a political and security pillar on paper, but there is no security architecture, no commitment of one member to another and no mechanism that would let one member count on the rest. Had it ever developed a security dimension, it might have carried more weight.

While it is true that Trump believes BRICS is a challenge to American power, that challenge exists more in his fantasies than anywhere else. But, Trump's fantasies have done more to shape the context of this summit than any leader who attended it. Because of the tariff threat he has held over the grouping, India kept de-dollarisation debate off the table, describing local currency settlement as mere diversification. Can a grouping that softens its own communiqué to avoid a tariff be a pole? It is a group of countries that know where power still sits and use the forum to negotiate with that power. BRICS can bring focus back on things that great power rivalry distracts from the global agenda: supply chains, food and energy security, development finance, digital infrastructure, climate, health. Indeed, India's chairmanship has been built around these questions, and rightly so.

So, what does India want BRICS to be? Who does it benefit? If hypothetically, BRICS becomes a pole against the US-led order, would that be in Delhi's interest?

A strong BRICS would put India on the adversarial side of the US and its allies, at a time when India's most important relationships are with them.

A strong BRICS would also carry higher stakes within the grouping, and higher stakes produce more interests, factions and politics inside the grouping. India is not the most influential State in BRICS today, and it would not be in a strong BRICS either. And a strong BRICS, in the end, could potentially contribute to the creation of an order in which China would be the most consequential power.

BRICS is useful for hedging, and for keeping adversaries close, especially when friends are acting up. It is a messaging platform and a pressure group which brings leaders with very different views into the same room, where some of those differences get talked through, if not resolved.

There is nothing wrong with more socialisation among these leaders. What works for India then is a BRICS that is neither strong nor weak, that talks a lot and does a little. That leaves India free to pursue its ambitions elsewhere.

The theory of BRICS as a grand counter pole lives only in the commentary around it. Not in reality.

Happymon Jacob is founder and director, Council for Strategic and Defense Research, and editor, INDIA'S WORLD magazine. The views expressed are personal

{ CYRIL RAMAPHOSA } PRESIDENT, SOUTH AFRICA



{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar



Growing reach of Hindi and regional languages

Last week, while addressing India's Gen Z and Gen Alpha, Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi chose to speak in Hindi. He could have chosen Gujarati, as the event was being organised in Vadodara. However, Modi wanted to reach a larger audience. Hindi, thus, was the right choice.

This is the reason he chose Varanasi along with Vadodara as a perfect option from where to contest the 2014 Lok Sabha elections. After winning both seats, he chose Varanasi. The corridors of power believe all roads to New Delhi pass through Uttar Pradesh — before Modi, Uttar Pradesh has given seven PMs to the country.

The importance of Hindi and the Hindi belt is acutely articulated by politicians from the non-Hindi-speaking parts of the country. After PM Jawaharlal Nehru's demise in 1964, a powerful faction within the Congress Party requested party president Kumaraswami Kamaraj to become the PM. He declined, insisting he didn't know Hindi, which was necessary to become PM.

On Hindi Day (September 14), I can say with pride that Hindi is acquiring a global footprint. According to data from the international database, Ethnologue, the total number of people who can speak, understand and use Hindi language stands at over 610 million. It includes people listing it as their mother tongue as well as those who mention it as their second or third language of preference. Ninety percent of them live in India. The remaining 10% live outside the country and act as its brand ambassador.

The majority of Hindi-speaking population outside India is concentrated in Nepal, the UAE, the US, Mauritius, Fiji, Guyana, Trinidad, the UK, and Canada.

I am mentioning this for a reason. The GDP of all these countries will total around 50% of the global GDP. Almost 30 to 40 million NRIs regularly contribute financially to their relatives, religious institutions, saints, etc. Remittances are key to our foreign exchange reserves.

However, this isn't the only source of foreign capital. Our artists and films earn millions in foreign markets. If you want to have influence in a country, you must send your people even before opening an embassy.

This is the reason we see politicians in the UK, the US, and Canada celebrating Hindu and Sikh festivals. These countries have seen large Indian immigrant influx since the 19th century.

Before Independence, when Mahatma Gandhi along with his close associates tried to establish Hindi as the national language, some Congress leaders from the non-Hindi speaking states voiced concerns. After a lot of deliberations, it was decided that for the initial 15 years every state will use English for official work and then a decision on the language would be taken considering the prevailing conditions in the future.

If we are proud of our language, then we should also respect the regional languages as well. Rasool Gamzatov, the legendary writer of *My Dagestan*, once wrote that if the Avar language was his mother, then Russian and other languages would be his aunts. Whatever politics or politicians might say, languages can act as bridges between people. Indians have proved this: Had it not been the case, the language movements of the 1960s and 1970s would have ripped India apart.

However, the AI age offers us a unique chance to correct our past mistakes. Today, anyone can easily watch films starring South Indian actors like Mammootty, Mahesh Babu, Mohanlal, Vijay and Allu Arjun dubbed in Hindi. Let me share its positive impact. In November 2024, during the release of *Pushpa 2's* trailer, South Indian star Allu Arjun visited Patna. A crowd of 1.5-2 lakh people gathered to welcome him. Most of them were from Gen Z or Gen Alpha.

This is the reason the 80-100 million Hindi-speaking people living in the non-Hindi speaking states face no social or economic issues. Social media too is playing its part in bridging the gap. It's creating new idioms that feature amalgamation of words and terms from different local and foreign languages. The internet age could very well achieve what our forefathers only hoped for fondly.

As far as Hindi is concerned, I am as confident and optimistic about its future, and proud of its glorious past. Best wishes to all on Hindi Day!

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. The views expressed are personal



Centre-left Oppn bloc holds lead in Swedish vote
STOCKHOLM: Sweden's centre-left opposition parties, which back Social Democrat leader Magdalena Andersson for prime minister, held an early lead at 51.3% in a parliamentary election on Sunday, an exit poll by broadcaster SVT showed. Some 8mn people were eligible to vote in the election. **REUTERS**

Scotland, Wales and N Ireland seek referendum rights
NEW DELHI: Leaders from Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland are expected to sign a deal on Monday to initiate the process of break-up of the UK, The Telegraph reported. The joint declaration seeking the right to hold independence referendums will be signed by the Scottish, Welsh and Irish first ministers at a summit in Cardiff. **HTC**

Donald Trump's childhood home sells for \$2 million
NEW YORK: Donald Trump's childhood home has sold for nearly \$2 million after a renovation transformed the New York City residence from a mold-ridden cat den to a modern abode. **AP**

Canada pushing to become 'associate member' of EU
BRUSSELS: Canada's Prime Minister Mark Carney wants a closer relationship with the EU and is exploring whether his country could become an "associate member" of the bloc, the Wall Street Journal reported. **REUTERS**

Iran to formally unveil Hormuz shipping pact to Gulf nations

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

TEHRAN: Iran plans to formally unveil an agreement on a temporary shipping lane through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday, after a flurry of diplomatic activity including a rare meeting between senior officials from Tehran and Abu Dhabi.

The Islamic Republic is set to reveal to Gulf nations its agreement with Oman on a temporary new shipping lane, according to a person familiar with the matter. Negotiations on details such as the fees ships may be charged will continue between the two countries later, they said, asking not to be identified discussing private deliberations.

Talks between Tehran and Muscat over the waterway, a global chokepoint for energy exports, have progressed in recent weeks and the latter had been aiming to bring together foreign ministers from the Gulf Cooperation Council on Monday in Salalah, a southern Omani city.

Tehran has indicated any deal won't amount to a full reopening and it'll still decide on which ships can cross the strait. Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi described the proposed meeting as an "important event" and a step towards building trust, in an interview with Al Araby Al Jadid.

It's not clear which nations would attend the purported gathering. Bahrain has ruled out participating, citing recent Iranian-backed attacks on Gulf sites, while escalating fighting between Saudi Arabia-backed forces and the Houthis, a group based in neighbouring Yemen and supported by Iran, may also complicate the plans.

The conflict that began late February with US and Israeli



Vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, off Musandam, Oman

REUTERS

Fighting in Yemen intensifies as Houthis strike Saudi Arabia

ADEN: The conflict in Yemen intensified on Sunday, as government forces launched attacks against Iran-backed Houthi rebels along the Red Sea and Houthi fired into neighbouring Saudi Arabia, which supports Yemen's government.

The Yemeni government vowed to send more forces to the Red Sea coast after conceding a "painful" defeat last week when Houthis captured the port city of Mokha and an island on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a crucial shipping alternative to the Strait of Hormuz.

strikes on the Islamic Republic has upended regional economies, with Tehran moving to shutter the Strait of Hormuz.

Brent crude oil prices have topped \$105 a barrel in recent days as renewed Middle Eastern tensions heightened concerns about global supplies. Soaring prices at the pumps pose a problem for President Donald Trump's Republican Party with

Saudi authorities sounded sirens on Sunday afternoon in the southern city of Abha and Khamis Mushait province, warning residents to take shelter from potential incoming fire. Both areas were repeatedly attacked by the Houthis in recent weeks.

The Houthis claimed to have used drones and missiles to target Saudi Arabia, including a military base just over the border with Yemen. Houthi military spokesperson Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree didn't provide evidence or say when the attack occurred. **AP**

just over 50 days to go before midterm elections.

Trump on Sunday sought to allay concerns over rising costs, predicting the conflict would end "right after" or "maybe before" the vote. Whenever it does, he said, "gasoline's going to drop like a rock".

The US and Iran exchanged strikes on oil tankers in the Persian Gulf earlier this month.

Trump: 'Negative forces' raising exaggerated concerns over AI

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

DOONBEG, IRELAND: US President Donald Trump on Sunday likened critics of artificial intelligence to "very negative forces" bringing up scenarios that will not happen, and said he wanted to make sure that the US remains the industry leader.

"We're leading China in AI. We're the most sophisticated country in the world, and frankly I want to keep it that way because whoever wins AI wins," Trump told reporters at his Ireland golf course, when asked if the AI industry should slow down or be more regulated.

"We could put guardrails. We can do this and that. But I think you have a lot of very negative forces that are bringing it up that shouldn't be bringing it up and they're bringing up things that won't happen."

OpenAI chief says no IPO this year amid safety issues

WASHINGTON: OpenAI won't go public in this year as the artificial intelligence company focuses on addressing safety-related concerns around the technology, CEO, Sam Altman told Fortune in an interview.

Altman said this year would be an "ill-advised moment" for initial public offering (IPO) and that a listing won't take place

until next year, according to a video of Fortune's interview. "I think it is unacceptable to be taking like a 10% chance of killing everybody by the end of the decade," Altman said. The comments come as Altman, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei and xAI co-founder chief Elon Musk all voiced the need to slow the pace of AI development due to escalating risks from the technology for humanity. **BLOOMBERG**



Trump has resisted stirring concerns about AI.

The public debate about AI has heated up in the US after

two Anthropic researchers issued warnings that the rapidly progressing technology could lead to the extinction of the

{ **INDONESIA** } 108 PEOPLE RESCUED

6 die, 129 missing as ferry capsizes

BANJARMASIN, INDONESIA: Rescuers in Indonesia said at least six people were killed and 129 others were missing after a ferry capsized in rough seas on Sunday, with one survivor recounting scenes of panic as passengers scrambled for life jackets.

The Virgo Transport 8 — which authorities said carried 213 passengers and 30 crew — lost contact with its shipping company early Sunday after departing from Surabaya in East Java. Basarnas, Indonesia's national search and rescue agency, said six people were killed and 129 others were missing. Another 108 people were rescued.

Two helicopters were involved in the search, as well as other vessels from the navy, police, the rescue agency and the ferry company.

AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE



The bottom of passenger ferry Virgo Transport 8 is seen above the water in the Java Sea, on Sunday.

AP

human race in the not-too-distant future.

In his second term, Trump's administration has largely embraced AI firms. These AI leaders and other technology companies have also supported Trump's initiatives.

On Saturday, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei outlined a three-step framework intended to pace development and create more time to manage its risks. The proposal immediately received endorsements from several other executives at major AI companies, including SpaceX CEO Elon Musk and OpenAI CEO Sam Altman.

In an interview that aired on Sunday on the CBS program me "Face the Nation with Margaret Brennan", Amodei said the competition between US and Chinese AI companies was the "toughest dilemma" in trying to establish a "speed limit" on the rate of AI development.

RUSSIAN DRONE HITS PASSENGER TRAIN, MISSES 'DIPLOMATIC TRAIN'

KYIV/MOSCOW: A Russian drone hit a passenger train on Ukraine's border with NATO member Poland on Sunday, shortly after former British Prime Minister Boris Johnson and other European diplomats had used the same line.

The train, on a route frequently used by foreign delegations returning from Kyiv, was attacked just 2 kilometres from the Polish border, Ukraine's railway operator said.

No casualties were reported.

"This wasn't our train, but the one just minutes after us by the border crossing. It was evacuated as the drone approached and no one was hurt," Carl Bildt, former Sweden's Prime Minister said on X. He and other politicians were returning to Europe by train after attending a conference in Kyiv. **REUTERS**

MY INDIA

{ **DEFENCE MINISTRY'S 2025-26 ANNUAL REPORT** }

'PLA deployments along LAC had thinned in 2025'

Rahul Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Chinese deployments along the contested Line of Actual Control (LAC) thinned last year, the defence ministry has said, noting that sustained engagements between India and China contributed to positive developments and stability along the country's northern borders.

"The year 2025 witnessed a significant reduction in the deployment of People's Liberation Army (PLA) forces opposite the northern borders," the defence ministry said in its latest annual report, reviewed by HT. The Chinese PLA had positioned 10 combined arms brigades along the LAC, with another 10 stationed in traditional training areas away from the frontier, the 2025-26 report said.

This translates into an estimated 40,000-50,000 Chinese troops along the LAC last year, and an equal number based in the designated training areas. The 323-page report did not specify the number of PLA troops deployed along the LAC in the previous year. However, the figure was estimated to be more than 60,000 in the Ladakh sector alone before the two sides reached an understanding in October 2024 on disengaging troops from all friction points, ending a standoff that lasted more than four years and took ties to a six-decade low.

"The bilateral interactions between India and China at political, diplomatic and military levels facilitated positive developments along the northern borders," it said. The Indian Army's deployment in all sectors along the LAC is robust, and the force is prepared to deal with any emerging contingency, it said.

The report covers developments up to March 31, 2026, and predates the latest tensions between the Indian Army and the PLA at Taksing, a remote area in Arunachal Pradesh's Upper Subansiri district. India on Saturday empha-



Indian and Chinese border posts at Nathu La.

SHUTTERSTOCK

sised that peace and tranquillity in the border areas remain the "essential basis" for developing ties with China, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping welcomed "steady progress" in bilateral relations during a meeting on the margins of the Brics Summit in New Delhi.

Xi travelled to India for the first time in seven years to attend the Brics Summit, setting up the meeting with Modi to take forward the normalisation of bilateral ties amid lingering tensions on the border. The two leaders last met on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit in the Chinese city of Tianjin a year ago.

The two leaders met against the backdrop of fresh tensions between the two armies in Arunachal Pradesh, with reports of face-offs during July and August. The talks also offered an opportunity to take stock of several rounds of dialogue between the Special Representatives on the border issue, the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC), and senior military commanders. India and China held the first round of talks between military commanders in the eastern sector in Arunachal Pradesh on September 6 and 7.

It marked the first corps commander-level engagement in the sector days after the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives of India and China on the boundary question

in Beijing.

The annual report also delved into Operation Sindoor, and the lessons learnt from the four-day military confrontation with Pakistan in May 2025. "After the operation, India undertook a comprehensive review of capability voids with a clear focus on force restructuring, enhancing jointness and integrating emerging technologies," it said. The inability of the local industry to offer niche products in the unmanned aerial systems (UAS)/ counter-UAS/ loitering munitions domains came to the fore during Operation Sindoor, the report pointed out.

Operation Sindoor highlighted the importance of jointness among the armed forces, it said.

"Theatre-isation is imperative to meet future challenges and pave the way for seamless synergy between the services. With accomplishment of 29% deliverables and completion of 35% joint doctrines, time has come to achieve all jointness and integration initiatives in a timely manner. The integration initiatives are focused on operational readiness to include capability development, maintenance, administration, human resource management and legal aspects," the report added.

Jointness is an essential prerequisite for creating theatre commands. These commands will integrate military elements, assets, and personnel from the three services under a single commander-in-chief.

4 killed in 2 Manipur attacks

Thomas Ngangom

letters@hindustantimes.com

IMPHAL: Four people, including a couple, were killed and a six-year-old sustained a bullet injury in two separate attacks carried out by armed miscreants in Manipur's Tamenglong district on Sunday, officials confirmed.

According to the police, the first incident occurred at around 5.30 am at Tollen village, where a 46-year-old woman, Lhingzangai Singit, was shot dead on the spot while her husband Seineh Singit succumbed to bullet injuries. The second attack, in which a man and a woman were killed, took place in Longpi village in the district around 10 hours later.

Chief minister Y. Khemchand Singh expressed deep anguish over the killings. "Such cowardly acts of violence against innocent civilians are unacceptable and have no place in our society," a statement issued by the CM's office said, extending condolences to the grieving families.

{ **Y KHEMCHAND SINGH** } MANIPUR CM

Such cowardly acts of violence against innocent civilians are unacceptable and have no place in our society



Police said a probe is underway to identify the culprits involved during the attack and no groups have claimed responsibility so far.

The injured in Tollen village were taken to Silchar Medical College, Assam, however, the husband succumbed on the way to hospital, officials said, adding that the minor is undergoing treatment at the same hospital and is stable.

Kaimai village authority con-

demned the attack, describing it as a "deliberate and malicious attempt to create disharmony, suspicion and division between different communities."

The village authority demanded to conduct a thorough and impartial probe to identify the perpetrators and bring them to justice.

A second attack was carried out at Longpi village in Tamenglong at around 3 pm. A woman and a man

were shot dead in the attack, police said. "Longpi is located around 30 km west from the police station. Due to non-motorable road condition no police personnel have been able to reach the spot. But we will conduct a spot enquiry on Monday morning," Nungba police said.

Western Village Volunteer (WVV), a Kuki group, claimed the deceased were identified as Jilie Singson and Reol Gangte of Longpi village. The group alleged that the attack was carried out by factions belonging to NSCN-IM and ZUF-K (National Socialist Council of Nagaland-Issac Muivah and Zeliangrong United Front-Kamson) cadres. "Following the killings, the attackers allegedly advanced towards the village centre but were confronted and driven back after a gunfire with the Western Village Volunteers," WVV claimed in a statement.

The incident coincided with the "Black Day", observed annually on September 13 by Kukis to remember the victims of ethnic violence during the Kuki-Naga conflict in the state in the 1990s.

SC lets manager off the hook, puts focus on Indian Bank in 35-year-old loan case

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: For more than three decades, a bank manager was made to answer for an alleged loss caused to Indian Bank by loans sanctioned in 1991-92. But when the Supreme Court finally acquitted him, it was the bank that found itself in the dock — over why it had kept more than ₹2.7 crore in excess auction proceeds with itself for years instead of handing the money over to the borrowers' legal heirs.

In a striking turn in the 35-year-old case, the Supreme Court has not only overturned the conviction of V Balakrishnan, then branch manager of Indian Bank's Anna Nagar branch, but also summoned the bank to explain what it did with the surplus money left after auctioning mortgaged properties

to recover the loans.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran noted that the bank received ₹1.175 crore from the auction of one borrower's property against loan dues of only ₹16.42 lakh, while another auction fetched ₹2.42 crore against dues of just ₹5.35 lakh. A further property fetched ₹34.5 lakh, which was also appropriated towards the loan account.

The court said the loans had been fully satisfied, yet the excess money from the auctions was still lying with the bank. "More intriguing is the fact... that the amounts received in auction, in excess of the appropriation to the loan accounts are still remaining with the bank," said the bench, expressing surprise that "no attempt was made to find out the legal heirs and pass on the money". The court has now impleaded the branch manager of

Indian Bank's Anna Nagar branch and ordered him to submit a report on the two loan accounts. The bank has also been directed to produce the title deeds of the mortgaged properties.

The case will return before the Supreme Court on October 5, specifically to ascertain the status of the excess auction money and ensure its due disbursement.

Balakrishnan had been working as branch manager in 1991 when CBI alleged that he conspired with P Kumaradevan, a retired Indian Overseas Bank officer, to sanction loans to two borrowers who were allegedly Kumaradevan's domestic helps. The prosecution case was that inflated property valuations were used to secure the loans and that Kumaradevan ultimately appropriated the money.

A CBI court convicted Balakrishnan in 2016 and sentenced him to one year's rigorous impris-

onment, more than two decades after the alleged irregularities. The high court upheld the conviction, bringing the matter to the Supreme Court.

But the apex court found the prosecution evidence fundamentally deficient. It noted that the loans had in fact been sanctioned by the Indian Bank's Regional Office, with official witnesses acknowledging the approvals. The bank subsequently recovered the loan amounts in full by auctioning the mortgaged properties.

The court also found that the prosecution had failed to establish that Kumaradevan had actually signed the cheques through which the loan amounts were allegedly received by him. It further rejected the inference that the properties must have been overvalued in 1991-92 simply because they fetched substantially higher prices when auctioned in 2010.

SHAH PITCHES FOR LEADERSHIP IN LAB-GROWN DIAMONDS

Faisal Malik

faisal.malik@htlive.com

MUMBAI: On a visit to the Bharat Diamond Bourse in BKC to attend a felicitation programme, Amit Shah pitched for the emerging sector of lab-grown diamonds. The home minister said that India had the infrastructure, energy, capital and entrepreneurial strength to capitalise on the expected growth in the global lab-grown diamond market and become a leader.

"India should build the entire value chain for lab-grown diamonds domestically—from manufacturing the machinery required to produce them to jewellery manufacturing, branding, showrooms and global sales," he said. He urged Indian companies to scale up operations, create global brands and establish their own sales centres in major international cities, assuring the industry of the Centre's support.

Shah also promised the gems and jewellery industry a large tract of land and the required FSI in Navi Mumbai.

NAGALAND: NINE PERSONS KILLED IN SUSPECTED HOOCH TRAGEDY

Alice Ythoshü

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOHIMA: A total of nine people died in the last three days after consuming suspected spurious liquor in Nagaland's eastern district of Tuensang, senior police officers said on Sunday.

"Nine deaths are confirmed as they had all died in the district hospital with similar symptoms. However, there could be more unreported cases," director general of police (DGP) Nagaland Rupin Sharma said. Preliminary enquiries revealed that most of the deceased had consumed liquor prior to developing symptoms including blurred vision, severe headache and dizziness.

West Asia crisis lifts India tanker rates

Rituraj Baruah and
Subhash Narayan

rituraj.baruah@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Daily charter hire rates for tankers to India have more than doubled to \$250,000 in about two weeks, as escalating hostilities in the Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz push up the cost of shipping oil to the world's third-largest oil importer, three people familiar with the developments said.

Rates have risen 150% from about \$100,000 as Houthi forces seized control of Yemen's Mocha port near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the people said. Bunker fuel prices have also risen 50% to \$900 a tonne, while insurance costs have increased 20%, adding to the cost of imports.

Iran-backed Houthi forces seized Yemen's Red Sea port city of Mocha last week and have since advanced toward the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, reaching the strategically located Perim (Mayun) Island and further threatening shipping through the key Red Sea chokepoint, according to Reuters and other reports. The development comes as traffic through the Strait of Hormuz remains severely disrupted, raising the risk of further pressure on shipping and energy supplies in the region.

"The situation has completely reversed over the past week," said Anil Devli, CEO of the Indian National Shipowners' Association (INSA). "Seafarers are now worried to take the Strait of Hormuz route. There was some movement earlier, but now there is none, as now both ships are being attacked and sunk, shippers killed, while earlier they were mostly disabled and not allowed to move," he said.

The latest escalation is a major concern for India as a likely Houthi takeover of Bab-al-Mandab could worsen disruptions and force tankers carrying Saudi Arabian oil to take the Suez Canal route, adding



The rise in tanker freight costs comes as India's crude import bill for Q1 has reached \$63.37 bn, up 56% from a year earlier. REUTERS

another two weeks to the voyage and potentially further pushing up global oil prices, according to shipping industry executives. Oil prices are already around four-month highs, with benchmark Brent crude near \$105 a barrel.

West Asia accounts for about 30% of India's current oil and gas imports.

The development is significant for India, as every \$1 increase in crude oil prices raises the annual import bill by ₹18,000 crore, affecting inflation and growth. In July, India's retail inflation rose to a 19-month high of 4.45%.

Devli of INSA added that tanker rates had eased to around \$70,000-80,000 a day about two months ago.

The increase in tanker freight costs comes as India's crude import bill for April-July this fiscal year has already reached \$63.37 billion, up 56% from a year earlier. This compares with a total oil import bill of \$123 billion in the previous fiscal year. The Indian crude basket was last recorded at \$115.98 a barrel on 9 September.

"The latest uncertainty in West Asia threatens to halt the revival of supplies and the eventual rise in prices adds to the supply constraints, as there are instances of Russian crude also

being sold at a premium," said an executive with a refiner, one of the three people cited above, requesting anonymity.

There is very limited movement of ships around the Strait of Hormuz and the little that moves, paying hefty war risk premium that has also gone up further high over the already elevated levels," said a UAE-headquartered logistics major DP World executive, who did not want to be named. DP World operates a global logistics and ports network across 80 countries and has a 10% share of global container traffic.

Queries emailed to India's ministries of ports, petroleum and state-run refiners Indian Oil Corp., Bharat Petroleum Corp. Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Ltd (HPCL) went unanswered.

The Centre launched the Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool (BMIP), a \$1.5 billion facility, in May, with a sovereign guarantee of \$1.4 billion to facilitate continuous maritime insurance coverage.

However, an executive with an Indian shipping company, speaking on condition of anonymity, said Indian ships are currently not plying through the affected routes and are therefore not using insurance support.

PWC US, INDIA TIE UP FOR JV TO SCALE GLOBAL CONSULTING

Devina Sengupta

devina.sengupta@livemint.com

MUMBAI: Auditing and consulting major PwC US and PwC India have signed a joint venture that will stitch together PwC India's Consulting business and PwC US Advisory's India-based capabilities into a single platform for its clients. Jointly owned and governed by both firms, the venture aims to position PwC India as a global player and serve as a single destination hub for client consulting services. The financial terms of the agreement were not disclosed.

While the JV is yet to receive regulatory approval, the streamlining of services is expected to give the firm an edge against its rivals EY, Deloitte, and KPMG. These companies, collectively referred to as the 'Big Four', are also consultants, and in some cases may compete with consulting heavyweights such as Kearney, Bain & Co., and McKinsey & Co.

The transaction is expected to close in the first half of 2027. Until then, PwC US and PwC India will continue to serve clients through their existing structures and ways of working. The structural changes apply strictly to the consulting and advisory divisions, as local regulations prohibit such integration within the firm's audit practice. *Mint* had reported these changes in PwC's advisory business in April. By realigning its consulting operations, the firm aims to break down legacy silos that historically slowed cross-border collaboration.

"The firms that win will be the ones that stop thinking about markets, capabilities, and delivery as separate pieces. That's what makes this combination so powerful," Paul Griggs, senior partner and CEO at PwC US, said in a statement on Sunday. "We're bringing the full breadth of our advisory talent in India together with PwC US—one team with the relationships, expertise, and scale to deliver for our clients and the PwC network."

Chip sector draws \$1.4 bn, with half raised since 2025

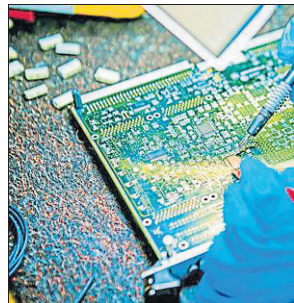
Press Trust of India

feedback@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: India's semiconductor sector has attracted \$1.4 billion in all-time equity funding across 281 funded companies, with nearly half of this amount - \$701 million - raised since 2025 alone, according to data from Tracxn. The findings come days ahead of SEMICON India 2026, the country's flagship semiconductor conference and exhibition, which will be held from September 17-19 at Yashobhoomi in Dwarka, New Delhi.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the fifth edition of SEMICON India 2026 on September 17, a mega-event set to bring together global semiconductor industry leaders, government officials, state representatives, and sector experts as India builds on the momentum of its growing semiconductor ecosystem.

India is home to 3,557 com-



India is home to 3,557 semiconductor and related firms. ISTOCKPHOTO

panies in the sector, of which 142 have raised equity funding, out of 281 funded companies. The sector recorded \$228 million in funding in 2026 year-to-date (YTD), according to Tracxn.

Tessolve Semiconductor leads the sector in cumulative funding at \$213 million till date, followed by ILJIN Electronics (\$198 million) and VVDN (\$129

million). Electronic Manufacturing Services has led the sector's funding, securing \$313 million since 2025.

Embedded Hardware ranked second, with \$51.9 million raised since 2025 - entirely within the trailing 12 months - while Power Management Integrated Circuits and Fabless Semiconductor Manufacturers were among the other leading business models by funding.

According to the report, the sector's funding rose from \$49 million in 2021 to \$473 million in 2025. The five-year funding compound annual growth rate (CAGR) stood at over 36%.

Bengaluru remained the dominant hub, home to 626 of the sector's 3,557 companies - about 18% of the total - and accounting for 40.1% of all equity funding raised to date. It was followed by Noida (16.4%), Gurugram (10.7%), Kochi (8.8%) and Hyderabad (6.2%) in terms of funding share.

BoFA's ₹18,268 CR TO COME BY DEC, SAYS JIO FINANCIAL

MUMBAI: Non-bank lender Jio Credit will get the capital of ₹18,268 crore from Bank of America (BoFA) by December this year once all the regulatory approvals for the infusion are in place, a top official at parent Jio Financial Services (JFS) has said.

Once the capital comes in, the entity will re-evaluate its business strategies and also product plans to accelerate growth in assets under management (AUM), the official said, adding that BoFA is "aligned" with the need for the book to grow fast.

Jio Credit's AUM can grow by around five times from the present ₹30,000 crore courtesy the capital infusion, JFS managing director and chief executive Hitesh Sethia told *PTI*, clarifying that this is the growth runway and not a timed target, which the business is working with.

The company will not need any new capital till the AUM touches up to ₹1.5 lakh crore, he added. **PTI**

IT firms rebrand software roles with AI label

Jas Bardia and
Yadukrishna C S

jas.bardia@livemint.com

BENGALURU/MUMBAI: Artificial intelligence (AI) may be creating fewer new jobs than what the openings listings suggest. The country's largest information technology (IT) firms seem to be rebranding old roles in software development, maintenance and business analytics with an AI label rather than creating new ones, at a time when the rise of the technology is posing an existential threat to the country's \$300 billion IT sector.

The trend is increasingly visible in hiring. According to industry experts and staffing firm representatives, as well as a Bernstein research report, much of what is being advertised as 'AI work' remains rooted in traditional technology roles, albeit with the use of AI tools. "Bulk of the new 'AI' vacancies dotted across employment platforms carry a lot of AI language and



The trend is increasingly visible in hiring. ISTOCKPHOTO

buzzwords, but are, in spirit, conventional software, data, cloud, or digital transformation work," Bernstein analysts Venugopal Garre and Nikhil Arela said in a note dated 3 September.

According to a *Mint* analysis of job portals of five of the country's largest tech services firms—Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Infosys Ltd, HCL Technologies Ltd, Wipro Ltd and Tech Mahindra Ltd—there are at least 3,500 AI roles. Top revenue-grosser TCS has at least 604 AI-related roles pertaining to IT developer,

engineer, customer support, and consultancy. Bengaluru-based Infosys, which is second ranked, has about 1,340. The third-largest HCLTech has about 1,376 roles with AI or automation titles, while the fourth-largest Wipro has at least 350 openings in AI engineering and consulting. Most of these roles include IT integration using AI tools.

On the other hand, at India's fifth-largest IT services firm, Tech Mahindra, about 42 roles of the 61 have AI-related titles or skill sets. The positions are technical lead, AI content analysts and GenAI consultants.

Tech Mahindra said the company sees this as an evolution of existing roles and not rebranding. "Most traditional job roles are increasingly absorbing AI as a skill. There is currently only a small set of roles that are purely AI-focused. For most employees, it is essentially 'what you do, plus AI,' chief people officer Richard Lobo said. The other IT companies mentioned did not

respond to *Mint's* queries.

A common thread running through all postings is that most are traditional IT roles requiring use of AI tools in software maintenance, content, data analysis, and even research purposes.

A staffing firm head attributed this to clients' needs.

"They are doing it because they need the candidate to have knowledge of using an AI tool, writing software, and collaborating with an AI tool. Like when Java came, a lot of jobs were in Java, now nobody blinks an eyelid if it's a Java job," said Aditya Mishra, managing director and chief executive of CIEL HR.

The Bernstein analysts stick their neck out to say that new jobs were not created for AI. "AI's employment promise, when viewed through evidence rather than excitement, looks less and less like a broad-based job-creation cycle and more like a profound redistribution of economic gains," said the Bernstein analysts.

FUEL EXPORTS TO RUSSIA HIT A RECORD IN AUG

Rituraj Baruah

rituraj.baruah@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Russia imported a record 172,000 tonnes of petroleum products in August, with most of the supplies coming from India, according to a report by Finnish think tank Centre for Research on Energy and the Clean Air (CREA).

The report noted that supplies from Nayara's Vadinar refinery comprised 70% of Russia's product imports, followed by supplies from South Korea.

"Ukrainian strikes on Russia's refining capacity have turned tables on the world's once largest oil product exporter to see them start importing fuels, with imports surging to a record 172,000 tonnes in August—more than seven times the previous monthly high. Russia was forced to import fuel from South Korea and buy back gasoline refined from its own crude in India," said the report.

All of the petrol from India was loaded at the Vadinar refinery and sold to Nayara Energy by Rosneft, CREA said. Rosneft owns 49.13% of Nayara Energy, while Vadinar sourced all of its crude from Russia during the first eight months of 2026, the report said.

Russia typically imports only small volumes of refined oil products.

FPIs WITHDRAW ₹13,138 CR FROM EQUITIES IN SEPT

Press Trust of India

feedback@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Foreign investors pulled out ₹13,138 crore from Indian equities in the first half of September, as heightened global uncertainty pushed crude oil prices higher, while rising US bond yields and a firm dollar weighed on risk appetite.

The latest outflow comes after Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) turned net buyers in July and August, infusing ₹20,200 crore and ₹29,630 crore, respectively, according to data from the Central Depository Services (India) Ltd (CDSL).

Prior to that, FPIs remained net sellers for four consecutive months from March to June.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

Across

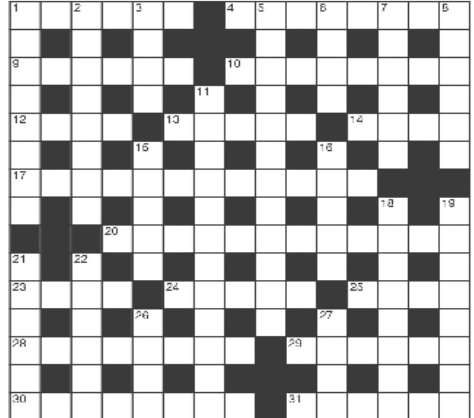
- The pattern of old China (6)
- Vouch for the account many tried falsely (8)
- Unable to see scattered group of stars (6)
- Play without stress (8)
- Swing till dizzy (4)
- Country has right to mountain range (5)
- Mount hotly tipped when it runs (4)
- Get a move on and stamp out garrulity (4,2,3,3)
- A butchery firm owned by a combine? (5,7)
- Game bird? (4)
- Enormous soldier ant (5)
- This man gets a seat (4)
- Fail to notice what supervisors do (8)
- She plays a Shakespearean part for the network (6)
- Push the boat out and depart (5,3)
- Avoided potential duel with editor (6)

Down

- Elevating device that may go over well (8)
- Stuck for some means of identification? (8)
- Rings about the Italian art exhibits perhaps (4)
- Unlikely to be patient much longer? (12)
- It's used to catch small river fish (4)
- Note the world shortage (6)
- It is twice raised by an outstanding painter (6)
- Postponing a mistake on the green? (7,2,3)
- Moving arm up and down (5)
- Grand aunt looks haggard (5)
- Given and ideally shouldn't be paid back (8)
- Crooked men about to plot in an underground vault (8)
- Tolerates Burns? (6)
- See under one kind of fruit for another (6)
- A shade sorrowful (4)
- Loss from a strike (4)

PUZZLE 17520

©GeminiCrosswords2018 All rights reserved



QUICK CLUES

Across

- Outlying city district (6)
- Blind alley (3-2-3)
- Wine bottle twice normal size (6)
- Uncomplimentary remark (8)
- Touch along a border (4)
- Aggressively self-assertive (5)
- An abandoned child (4)
- Very nervous (6,6)
- Work perfectly (2,4,1,5)
- Strongly audible (4)
- Nimble (5)
- Surfeit (4)
- Mention in dispatches (8)
- Tedious moral discourse (6)
- Prevailing (8)
- Out-of-date (3,3)

Down

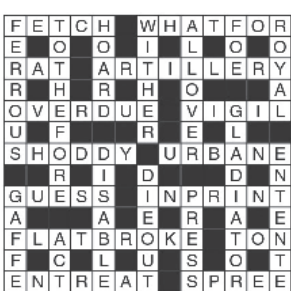
- Fellow-feeling (8)
- Be reluctant to give (8)
- Disorderly retreat (4)
- Absolutely (12)
- Prisoner's place in court (4)
- Pedestrian tunnel under road (6)
- Isolated (3,3)
- Sharp reprimand (8-4)
- Mixture of metals (5)
- Slyly derogatory (5)
- Almost (4-4)
- Bluish violet quartz (8)
- Calm (6)
- Patronage (6)
- Knock senseless (4)
- Very young horse (4)

SOLUTIONS FOR 17519

Cryptic



Quick



{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■ HIGH ■ LOW



MONDAY
Generally cloudy sky with moderate rain

31°C | 26°C



TUESDAY
Generally cloudy sky with moderate rain

31°C | 25°C



WEDNESDAY
Generally cloudy sky with moderate rain

32°C | 26°C

ALMANAC

Today is 14th September 2026

02 Rabi al Akhar, 1448

18, Bhadrapada, Shukla

Paksha, 03

Samvat 2083

Sunset: Monday at 06:42 pm

Sunrise: Tuesday at 06:26 am

Moonrise: Monday at 09:06 am

Moonset: Monday at 08:41 pm

TEMPERATURE IN FOUR METROS

Delhi 31°C | 25°C

Mumbai 31°C | 26°C

Kolkata 32°C | 28°C

Chennai 36°C | 26°C

SPORT

Raring to find control in the ring

Indian women boxers have done well internationally, but the key is to be ready for any situation, says head coach Nieva

Avishek Roy

avishek.roy@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: Kazakhstan's Elina Bazarova was pounding Preeti Pawar. The opening round of her first bout at the Senior Asian Championships had thrown Preeti into deep waters. She missed more than connecting while the quick-footed Elina landed blow after blow to take the first round 5-0 in the bantamweight fight.

Boxing can be cruel. The hard blows numb the minds of boxers, make their feet unsteady and toss the gameplan out of the ring. The instruction from the coach's corner was either take the second round to have any chance, or she would be packed off.

Preeti not only took the second round, she was so dominant that one of the judges gave a 10-8 card. In the third round, the southpaw kept up the pressure, bailing herself out of jail. Once she found her range, she was ran through her opponents. It included victories against Paris Olympics bronze medalist Im Aeji of South Korea and Chinese Taipei's Huang Hsiao-wen, a three-time world champion and an Olympic medalist.

Having beaten boxers with such credentials and won the Asian title, Preeti will enter the ring at the Asian Games as one of India's strong medal contenders. The 54kg boxer is also fresh from adding the Glasgow Commonwealth Games gold to her achievements.

Every competition is important for Preeti, but she considers them only a stepping stone towards the 2028 LA Olympics. In the 2024 Paris Olympics, she entered as one of the country's best talents but was raw and new to international boxing. A bout of Hepatitis A before the Games had drained her energy. Coming back after the last 16 loss in Paris, she was low, struggled to get her confidence back, and lost her place to Sakshi Chaudhary in the team. However, she has then staged an impressive comeback.

Training at the Army Sports Institute in Pune with quality sparring partners and coaches, she gradually built her strength and boxing and has now taken charge of the 54kg class. It has been quite a turnaround since winning the World Cup Finals at home.

"Boxing is both a physical and mental sport. We have to be mentally strong and sharp so that we can quickly react and defend punches," Preeti says.

"I have worked on my reaction skills, and most importantly on how to stay calm in the ring in pressure situations. When we face a tough opponent, there is pressure and it will always be there. What makes the difference is how we control it during the bout so that it doesn't affect our performance. I have been working on every front. I don't want to leave anything to chance for the LA Olympics," she says. The Asian Games, however, will bring its own set of challenges, the way she faced Bazarova.

"She was a bit slow in the first round. We asked her to show more energy, step back and counter, and put more pressure on the Kazakh boxer. We told her, 'If you don't win this round, it will be over for you.' The next two rounds she was fantastic," says Md. Aitesaamuddin, a coach with the Indian team who has also trained her at ASI, Pune.

"It took her some time to regain focus after Paris. In ASI, we have worked on her fitness. She used to rush and attack, now she has improved her defence, she is not going all out, and her movement in the ring is better," says

the Army coach.

Preeti is aware that all eyes will be on her and she is likely to get the same opponents she met in the Asian Championships in Ulaanbaatar earlier this year. But she is not overawed.

"Asian Games will be tough because some of the top boxing nations will be there. But the Asian Championships gold has given me a lot of confidence. I have competed against them recently. To beat the Paris Olympics medalist (Im Aeji), who is a good technical boxer and also a southpaw like me, was big. I was under a bit of pressure against her as to how I would box, how to cover, but I started well in the first round with a 5-0 card and kept her under pressure throughout."

She has also beaten the tall Huang Hsiao-wen at the World Cup Finals at home and the Asian meet. "I have faced her twice and my gameplan has worked against her," says Preeti. "Before the CWG, I told myself that I would focus on the performance and not on the medal. It will be the same in Japan."

Preeti's resurgence is part of a revival in Indian women's boxing. In Glasgow, the women's team won five of the seven gold medals on offer, giving a fillip to the overall medal tally on the final day. The Asian Games has five weight categories, but navigating the draw and going deep to secure a medal will be a much bigger challenge.

For women's team head coach Santiago Nieva, who rejoined Indian boxing earlier this year, it will also be an important test before the LA qualification cycle begins. In the last Asian in Hangzhou, the women returned with only three medals, and no gold. Preeti was one of the boxers to win a bronze.

"They have done well, winning many gold medals against different types of opponents, in Asia, in Europe, and now in the Commonwealth countries. So, we know we have a strong team. At the highest level, the margin is very small, but our boxers are competitive all the way. That is good. We want to have the boxers in the final and on top of the podium," says Nieva.

The promising Priya Ghanghas (60kg) and experienced Sakshi (51kg), who won gold medals in Glasgow, will face tougher tests. Tokyo Olympics bronze medalist Lovlina Borgohain, a seasoned champion, took silver in the previous edition and will have to work hard for a second successive podium finish in 75kg, while it will be interesting to see the performance of Parveen Hooda (65kg) on her comeback trail. "Asian Games is a very strong competition and Asian teams are improving. The last couple of Asian Games, we (women's team) have not won a gold medal. So that's our goal," said Nieva.

"The main thing is our boxers need to be good enough so that they can control whatever situation happens in the ring, and whatever style or different opponent that happens. We have made them aware of that, and then they can maintain their best boxing for longer periods of time. If we do the right things, we have a better chance to win. That's the only thing I can see. I need to make sure we don't fall into negative boxing that we lose control in the bout."

For the Indian women, the Asian Games will be a test of their growing strength and depth against the best in Asia. After the gold rush in Glasgow and a period of rebuilding, the challenge will be to turn that momentum into medals on the biggest stage.

Asian Games is a very strong competition and Asian teams are improving. The last couple of Asian Games, we (women's team) have not won a gold medal. So that's our goal

SANTIAGO NIEVA, women's team head coach

PREETI PAWAR

AGE **22**

WEIGHT CLASS **54KG**

FROM **HARYANA**

Packing a mean punch

The boxer was among the most impressive of the five women gold medallists at the 2026 Commonwealth Games

PREETI'S ACHIEVEMENTS

2022	ASIAN GAMES	B
2024	ASIAN U22 CHAMPIONSHIPS	G
2025	WORLD BOXING CUP	G
2026	COMMONWEALTH GAMES	G
2026	ASIAN CHAMPIONSHIPS	G

*Competed in 2024 Paris Olympics

KEY FACTS

- Preeti is from Haryana's Bhiwani district, known as mini Cuba for producing several top boxers
- She was introduced to the sport by her uncle, ex-boxer Vinod Pawar. Her father is with Haryana Police
- Naib Subedar with the Army and trains at Army Sports Institute, Pune. She won the 2026 nationals with SSCB

INDIA'S 2026 BOXING SQUAD

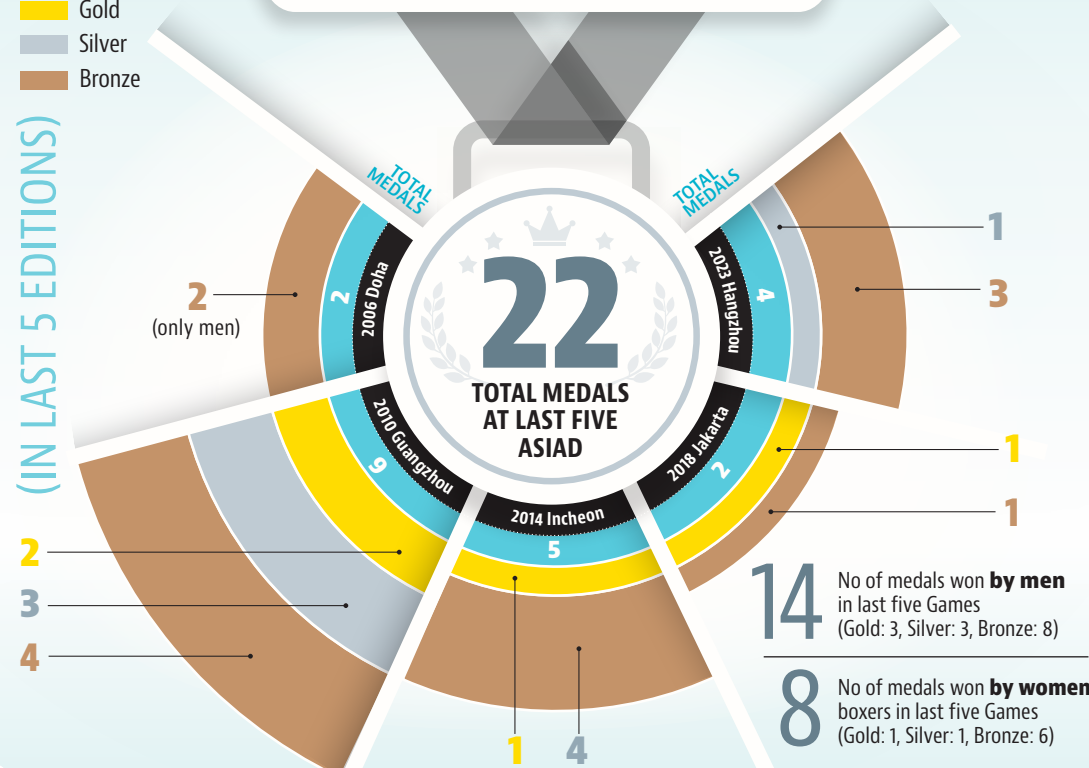
MEN

- Jadumani Singh (55kg)
- Sachin Siwach (60kg)
- Sumit Kundu (70kg)
- Ankush (80kg)
- Kapil Pokhariya (90kg)
- Narender Berwal (+90kg)

WOMEN

- Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg)
- Preeti Pawar (54kg)
- Priya Ghanghas (60kg)
- Parveen Hooda (65kg)
- Lovlina Borgohain (75kg)

INDIA'S MEDAL HAUL IN BOXING



GRAPHIC: ANKIT PANDEY

Games-bound boxers throw in bouts of team building

Shahid Judge

shahid.judge@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Since the start of the year, coaches in India's national boxing camp had made it a point to organise at least one fun-filled evening every month. A simple affair, with song and dance being a prominent feature, sometimes even a fancy dress party. "The last one we had was a beach theme, and I got first prize," men's boxing team head coach CA Kuttappa beams with pride as he tells HT. "These evenings lighten the mood, break the routine and help everyone bond."

Since August though, bigger nights of celebration have been in the works, to toast the strong showing by the boxing contingent at the CWG. The activity, however, has been put on hold for the time being. Right now, the aim is to build on the CWG momentum in the tougher competition at the Asian Games.

There was an upswing in performance from a young men's team that won two gold and two silver medals. This a year after the Indian men failed to even secure a podium spot at the World Championships for the first time in 12 years. "The boys did well at CWG, and to be honest, I never thought we would get such results," said the Dronacharya.

Kuttappa was re-appointed head coach of the men's team in January for his third stint. Soon after, in collaboration with women's team coach Santiago Nieva, he started to make a few changes in the way the boxers trained.

"What would generally happen is the players would come in for training, spar, and then leave. And that's it. I told all the coaches to watch the sparring sessions, and then analyse the videos of those sessions," Kuttappa said. "Then we would bring the boys and give them explanations of what went well, what needed to change. We would talk more about the positive stuff, and then make them work on correcting the errors."

A major part of the feedback was to change the focus of each bout. Instead of winning, the target was more performance-oriented – making sure the punches were accurate and the blocks were perfect.

"If I tell the boys they have to win, then they will start to fear losing. Instead, we have a step-by-step process. The main thing is they need to put up a fight so that even if they lose, people will say it was a solid performance. You do the simple things right and the results will follow."

At the CWG, Sachin Siwach (60kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg) won gold after pulling off hard-fought wins in their finals. Jadumani Singh (55 kg) (in pic) and Narender Beral (+90kg) took silver. The quartet, with Sumit Kundu (70kg) and Kapil Pokhariya (90kg), will form the men's Asian Games team.

Similarly, each of the five women's pugilists at the Asian Games also competed at the CWG. With that in mind, Kuttappa and Nieva ensured camaraderie was forged in the squad.

"Everyone trains together, and at the CWG, the boys were cheering for the girls' matches and the girls were supporting during the boys' bouts," Kuttappa said. "There is good team bonding. We are a family, and we're all together." After the Glasgow performances, there's optimism about the chances of a resurgent men's team in Japan.

Indian boxers though have won only eight gold medals in the Asian Games, heavyweight Hawa Singh having won two of them in 1966 and 1970.



T20I: Bumrah returns as India ease to victory

Samreen Razzaqui

samreen.razzaqui@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Abhishek Sharma had spent much of India's training time in the lead-up to the first T20I against Afghanistan bowling in the nets. On Sunday, however, it was with the bat that he made a big statement as India defeated Afghanistan by seven wickets at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

Returning to India's T20 World Cup-winning combination after Vaibhav Sooriyavanshi was left out to pair him with Sanju Samson at the top of the order, Abhishek played a commanding innings to set the tone after India skipper Shreyas Iyer won the toss and chose to bowl. Afghanistan made

156/8 and India reached 157/3 in 13.4 overs chasing.

If the extra bowling work was a reflection of the sluggish pitch conditions expected in Delhi, Abhishek took to attacking early, finding the boundary—he scored seven fours and sixes each—and putting India firmly in control of the chase. Ishan Kishan provided excellent support with 42 off 33 balls, complementing his batting partner. The duo dominated the Powerplay, helping India surge to 82/1, with Sanju Samson the only wicket to fall in that phase. Mohammad Nabi picked up 2/28 for Afghanistan.

At the start, Jasprit Bumrah's return to T20Is was emphatic. The India pace spearhead, back after an injury layoff, looked to be oper-

ating in familiar rhythm despite his time away and struck in his first over. Rahmanullah Gurbaz was surprised by the bounce from a back-of-a-length delivery, opening the face of the bat and only guiding it to Abhishek at slip.

Bumrah's return was a major talking point, but it was Arshdeep Singh who stole the bowling honours. The left-arm pacer produced an impressive spell to finish with 3/19 and was central to Afghanistan's collapse.

Afghanistan lost four wickets inside the Powerplay, leaving their hopes of posting a competitive total looking bleak. They were reduced to 43/5 inside seven overs with India's bowlers on top and the innings in danger of unraveling. Afghanistan, however, found

a route back through Azmatullah Omarzai and Mohammad Nabi. The experienced pair counter-attacked when their side needed it most, putting together an 83-run partnership that transformed the innings. From 43/5, Afghanistan recovered to 126/6 with Omarzai leading the charge. Nabi eventually fell for 33, triggering another cluster of wickets, but Afghanistan refused to fold.

Omarzai remained unbeaten on 64, carrying the innings through its difficult phases and ensuring Afghanistan reached a respectable 156/8.

Brief scores: Afghanistan 156/8 (A Omarzai 64, Arshdeep 3/19); India 157/3 in 13.4 ovs (Abhishek 82, I Kishan 42). **India won by 7 wickets.**



India's Jasprit Bumrah celebrates the dismissal of Afghanistan's Rahmanullah Gurbaz on Sunday.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT

Vande Mataram played before India T20I match

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: For the first time at a cricket match involving the India men's team, the national song, Vande Mataram, was played in full before the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana, ahead of the first T20I against Afghanistan at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Monday.

It is in keeping with new protocol that is expected to be followed before the start of series where the national anthem is traditionally played. The development follows the passage of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in late July. The amendment to Section 3 of the Prevention of Insults to

National Honour Act, 1971, extends to the national song, the same legal protection currently afforded to the national anthem.

Under the law, it thus makes it an offence to intentionally prevent the singing of Vande Mataram or cause a disturbance at an assembly where it is being sung. President Droupadi Murmu gave her assent to the Bill in August, bringing the amendment into law.

The protocol had already been implemented during the Delhi Premier League, with both Vande Mataram and Jana Gana Mana played before the final. However, the national song was not played before the Women's Asia Cup final between India and Sri Lanka in Dubai on Sunday.

Rybakina's turnaround with No.1, US title and a statement

The Kazakh player beats Sabalenka in a high-voltage women's final to claim her third Slam trophy

Rutvik Mehta
rutvik.mehta@htlive.com

Mumbai: Last month, Elena Rybakina wasn't sure if she would be able to play a match at the US Open. She played, and won, all seven.

Last season, Rybakina did not go past the fourth round of any of the four Grand Slams. This season, she went all the way in two.

Last year, on September 15, she was ranked world No.10. On September 14, 2026, she will be world No.1.

As the US Open champion. That's some stamp of statement to go with the turnaround tale.

The Russian-born Kazakh wasn't done dethroning the incumbent from the top spot. She took her title too on Saturday night. Rybakina defeated Aryna Sabalenka 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 for her first US Open crown after a high stakes, high quality final.

This was the 2022 Wimbledon champion's third Grand Slam trophy, and second this year after beating the Belarusian at the Australian Open too, after a similar three-set back and forth.

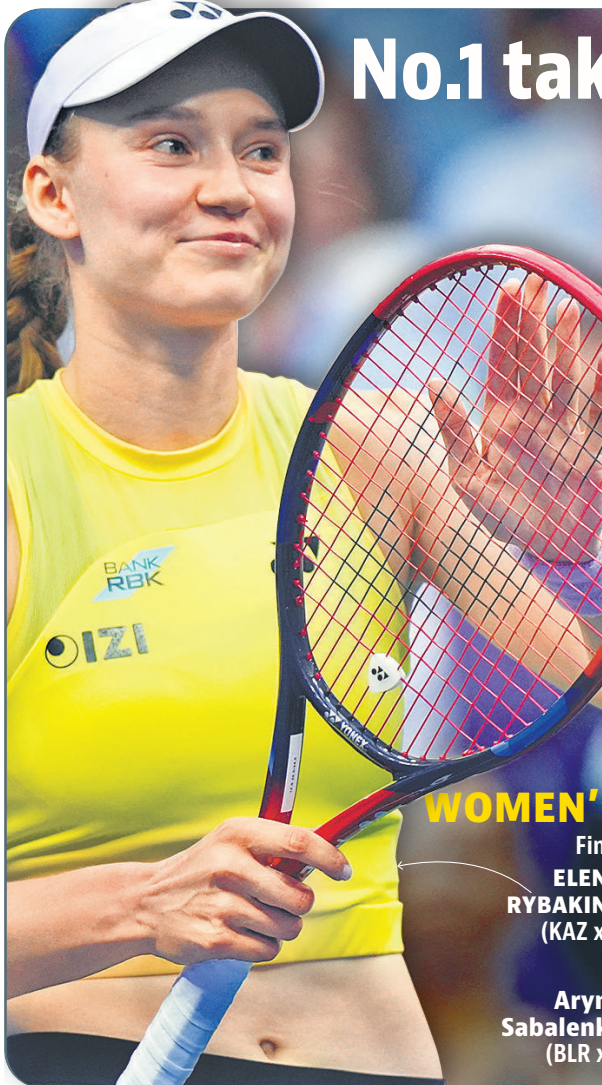
Yet, this US Open triumph felt different, perhaps more special, for the 27-year-old.

It takes a lot to get Rybakina to raise both her arms in celebration. Even more to walk around grinning. And even more to hold back tears on court.

"It's going to be very different to wake up knowing that you won the US Open and achieved the No.1 ranking," Rybakina said in the press conference. "This tournament was more stressful, because I was playing for No.1, and then this injury happened. Every day was a challenge."

That foot injury happened in Cincinnati 10 days before her first match in New York. Rybakina did not train for a week, and did not know how she would turn up at the US Open. With four straight-set sweeps in the first week and battling wins from a set down in the quarters and semis, Rybakina went from not making the last eight of the season-ending Slam before to being the last woman standing.

A frequent presence in the second week of majors, Rybakina wasn't herself last season. Her long time coach, Stefano Vukov, was suspended by WTA in January 2025 for an alleged code of conduct breach but



No.1 takes the crown

RYBAKINA		STATS		SABALENKA	
12	5	ACES	6	DOUBLE FAULTS	3
47	85	1ST SERVE %	58	WIN % ON 1ST SERVE	69
59	77	WIN % ON 2ND SERVE	50	% NET POINTS WON	67
25	36	% BREAK POINTS WON	33	WINNERS	32
24	35	UNFORCED ERRORS	35		

WOMEN'S Final

ELENA RYBAKINA (KAZ x2) bt ARYNA SABALENKA (BLR x1)

6	5	6
4	7	2

MEN'S DOUBLES Final

CHRISTIAN HARRISON/NEAL SKUPSKI (USA/ENG) bt KEVIN KRAWITZ/TIM PUETZ (GER) 6-4, 7-6 (8/6)



Elena Rybakina poses with the trophy and former Russian Grand Slam champion Maria Sharapova (R) after the final.

returned in August.

"A lot of things (were) happening," said Rybakina of last season. "Now I feel like I have a great team, great people around me. We continued the work. And it finally paid off."

That work gave her three biggest hard court titles -- the WTA Finals in 2025 and the two Slams in 2026, beating Sabalenka in all three finals. The Belarusian

smashed her racquet and sat with her team in stunned silence after the match.

The on-court personalities of the two rivals couldn't be more contrasting. Rybakina almost always keeps her emotions in check. Sabalenka almost always lets it rip.

She was on the edge emotionally early doors in the final. The battle between two of the biggest

ball strikers on the women's tour began with Rybakina executing two clean backhand winners and Sabalenka unleashing a couple of cracking ones off the forehand. The latter's though came while facing break points as the Sabalenka serve was under pressure. A stinging return and a solid backhand from the Kazakh set up another break point in the fifth game.

Sabalenka double faulted, smacked the ball into the stands and received a code violation.

By the time Rybakina held to love for 4-2, she was yet to make an error and had dropped just two of the 14 points on serve. Not that the big-server was sending down bullets. Rybakina made just 27% (8/30) first serves in the first set, a strikingly low percentage that Sabalenka's indecisive returns and wayward play failed to cash in. Rybakina took the set despite her biggest weapon not even loading optimally.

It did load better in the second set even as Sabalenka, who thwarted early trouble on serve before her quality picked up, got better too. Her first break point came as set points in the 10th game but Rybakina held on. Lit-

tle signs of annoyance cropped up from the second seed, and the top seed was tuned in to pounce. A drop shot winner for 30-30, a backhand crosscourt passing shot for deuce with Rybakina serving to stay in the set again. And when a wide Rybakina forehand set up a third set point, Sabalenka seized with a bludgeoning backhand second serve return that did not come back.

What did come back was Rybakina's hitting quality, shot placement, first serve efficiency and the level that made her fly high in New York. And off she went flying immediately in the decider.

Rybakina broke Sabalenka in the third game during a sizzling spell early in the set where she won 12 of the 15 points. Finishing off a volley at the net, she broke again in the seventh game after a serving stranglehold of dropping just one point on the first strike. She lost two more while serving for the championship. It didn't matter.

What mattered was the ace that sealed it. What mattered was that Rybakina's status as the world No.1 came with the US Open title. Stamped and sealed.

India win final, refuse to accept trophy from Naqvi



Indian players celebrate after taking a wicket during the final of the Women's T20 Asia Cup against Sri Lanka at the Dubai International Stadium on Sunday.

Shalini Gupta
shalini.gupta@htlive.com

CHANDIGARH: India demonstrated their class and depth when it mattered to defeat Sri Lanka by 72 runs and in the final of the Women's T20 Asia Cup in Dubai on Sunday. It was their eighth Asia Cup title overall, with five having coming in the 50-over format.

Harmanpreet Kaur's side produced a commanding all-round performance to reclaim the continental crown after two years, avenging the loss to Sri Lanka in the 2024 final.

India, however, refused to accept the trophy from ACC president Mohsin Naqvi, who is also the internal minister of Pakistan just like the men's team when they won the title in Sept last year.

India posted a formidable 183/5, powered by aggressive half-centuries from openers Shafali Verma (68 off 39 balls) and Smriti Mandhana (59 off 39 balls) and their 129-run opening stand in 12.5 overs. Sri Lanka

were dismissed for 111 off the last ball after spinners Shree Charani (4/20), Deepti Sharma (3/19) and Prema Rawat (1/22) dismantling the chase.

"We know they are a great team, but we played to our standards. We set high standards for ourselves and we wanted to keep matching them. Very happy the way we all performed," skipper Harmanpreet Kaur said after emphatic win.

She praised the openers for laying the foundation for the excellent total.

"The openers did a great job, the way Shafali and Smriti batted. It is great to see Shafali take responsibility throughout the tournament, with bat and ball," Harmanpreet said.

Shafali set the tone with a blistering knock, hitting nine fours and two sixes. Mandhana was fluent in her innings, with five fours and three sixes.

Mandhana was run out in the 14th over after a mix-up with Harmanpreet. It came two balls after Shafali's departure, but India finished strongly. Richa

Ghosh hit a brisk 17 off 13 and Harmanpreet 14.

Gunalan Kamalini made 15* off five balls, with a four and six.

Captain Chamari Athapaththu offered some resistance with 36 off 32 balls, while Vishmi Gunaratne made 20. But once Athapaththu was stumped off Deepti Sharma at 62/2, Sri Lanka's challenge unravelled. They lost four wickets for 18 runs between the 13th and 16th overs, ending any hopes of an improbable recovery.

The manner of India's victory was a reminder of the gulf between India and the rest of Asia. Sri Lanka had entered the final unbeaten and had shown character to overcome Pakistan in the semi-final. However, they were outplayed in virtually every department on Sunday.

India thus made amends for the 2024 final loss to Sri Lanka. **Brief scores: India 183/5 (S Mandhana 59, S Verma 68), Sri Lanka 111 in 20 ovs (C Athapaththu 36, S Charani 4/20, D Sharma 3/19). India won by 72 runs.**

MBAPPE SCORES DOUBLE IN REAL ROMP; YAMAL STARS FOR BARCA

Agencies
sportm@hindustantimes.com

MADRID: Kylian Mbappe struck twice to help Real Madrid smash Rayo Vallecano 4-1 on Saturday, before Lamine Yamal struck twice to help Barcelona to an exciting 4-2 win at Levante on Sunday, extending the Catalans' perfect start to the season.

Hansi Flick's side reestablished their three point lead over Real Madrid at the top of the table.

Jose Mourinho's side got back to winning ways after a defeat by Real Betis in their previous top-flight outing, with a convincing victory against neighbours Rayo.

Jude Bellingham and Alvaro Carreras were also on target for Real Madrid, while Sergio Camello pulled one back for the visitors early in the second half.

Mourinho's side took a commanding three-goal lead against Rayo by half-time.

"(It was) fundamental to win, above all after losing the last game in La Liga," Mourinho told Real Madrid TV.

"We killed the game in the first half -- that's not easy, working like we did after the Champions League game, not just physically, but mentally."

Los Blancos took the lead from the penalty spot in the 14th minute after Florian Lejeune clumsily felled Carreras. Mbappe sent Rayo goalkeeper Emil Audero the wrong way.

The French forward helped create the second, after Lejeune gave the ball away under pressure from Vinicius Junior. Carreras exchanged passes with Mbappe and drilled home.

Bellingham notched Madrid's third goal and his third of the season after Vinicius charged down the left and cut the ball back for the Englishman.



Real Madrid's Kylian Mbappe celebrates his first goal.

Nepo helps Ganges GMs to GCL title

Susan Ninan
sportm@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Ian Nepomniachtchi has waited a long time to beat Magnus Carlsen in a game that mattered. On Sunday, playing on the Icon board, the Russian GM--he lost to Carlsen in the 2021 World Championship match--powered his team, Ganges Grandmasters, to their maiden Tech Mahindra Global Chess League title by beating Alpine APL Pipers.

It's a funny thing with Carlsen and team events. The Pipers won the title the only year (2025) he didn't play the league. This time with a title defence on the line in season four and the world's best player leading on the Icon board, they tripped up.

In the two-match final, Grandmasters and Pipers drew 3-3 in their first face-off with Carlsen and Nepomniachtchi drawing their game.

In their second match-up colours were reversed and Carlsen, playing White, appeared to dip into his World Championship preparation, choosing to play the Catalan. The world No.1 unleashed a brilliancy with 19. Rd6 before Nepomniachtchi made a positional inaccuracy with 20. Qb7, while being a pawn

down. Carlsen seemed to move into a decisive advantage over the next bunch of moves, sliding his rook to d1.

Carlsen greedily grabbed Black's b5 pawn with his Queen and instantly found himself in a chokehold. Nepomniachtchi pushed his c-pawn up a square, opening up the diagonal for his bishop to gobble up White's f-pawn (29.Bxf2+), unleashing discovered check tactics. Nepomniachtchi had turned the game around and it was Carlsen who was in the trenches. The Russian bobbed in his chair and stretched his arms, flexing how good his position looked against the five-time world champion.

Black's rook was lined up against White's King and its c-pawn was three squares away from promotion. Carlsen knew he was staring down the barrel. He resigned before they reached move 40.

"I got insanely lucky. It was my only idea...Bxf2. It reminded me of some kids tournament when you badly hope that the guy will blunder something...and it worked out and I'm really happy that it helped my team," Nepo said.

In the third-place match, Fyers American Gambits defeated CheQ Mumbai Masters.

Antonelli rides his luck to win Spanish GP

Agencies
sportm@hindustantimes.com

MADRID: Championship leader Kimi Antonelli made the most of a slice of luck to claim his eighth win of the season in meticulous style as he steered his Mercedes to a measured victory in the Spanish Grand Prix at the Madring on Sunday.

The 20-year-old Italian extended his lead to 81 points after coming home 4.351 seconds ahead of Red Bull's four-time champion Max Verstappen with unlucky pole-sitter Lando Norris of McLaren third, just 0.738 seconds adrift.

Antonelli, who had won thrillingly from 19th on the grid in his home Italian race a week earlier, this time took full advantage of an early setback for McLaren's world champion Norris when he was caught out by an early Virtual Safety Car (VSC) intervention after leading for 15 laps.

"It was a very difficult race and not straightforward at all," admitted Antonelli who is set to become Italy's first world champion since Alberto Ascari in 1953.

"We had to manage the tyres, but it is good to win, although it feels not so good because Lando deserved to win."

Norris had led from pole, but lost his advantage when Aston Martin's Lance Stroll crashed to bring a VSC pause that was ill-timed for him as he passed the pits as it happened, gifting his rivals a "cheap" pit stop.

"There was nothing I could do about it. So, congratulations to them. I did my best and tried, but it was so difficult to pass Max and he made no mistakes. That's racing sometimes so we'll take it on the chin and try better next time."

Ferrari's Charles Leclerc, who led for most of the race at the Madring circuit, finished fourth ahead of George Russell.

Haaland fires 10-man Man City to memorable win over Man Utd

Agence France-Presse
sportm@hindustantimes.com

MANCHESTER: Erling Haaland fired 10-man Manchester City to a memorable 1-0 victory over Manchester United despite Phil Foden's first-half red card to extend a perfect start to Enzo Maresca's reign.

Foden kicked out at United captain Bruno Fernandes on 23 minutes to give the visitors a mountain to climb.

But a new-look City were up to the challenge as the near £250 million (\$340 million) midfield pairing of Elliot Anderson and Enzo Fernandez proved their worth.

Haaland's winner was laced with controversy as Fernandez was deemed not to be interfering with play when he attempted to head in before the ball reached the Norwegian.

Defeat compounds a miserable Premier League start for United as they are already eight points adrift of City and defending champions Arsenal.

By contrast, victory was a huge statement for Maresca to quell fears of a major drop-off from City following Pep Guardiola's trophy-laden decade in charge.

A fervent pre-match atmosphere was fuelled just as much by United fans' anger towards their own club as it was by the usual animosity between the supporters.

A crackdown on ticket touting in recent months has resulted in widespread condemnation from supporters' groups after many innocent people faced the threat of sanction.

A normal array of banners and flags in the Stretford End



Manchester City's Erling Haaland (left) scored the match-winner against Manchester United.

was replaced by just one bearing the message: "The way you treat us is a disgrace."

The visitors had made the better start in the opening quarter but looked to have been completely undone by Foden's ill discipline.

City will argue Fernandes should also have seen red as he fouled Foden and then kicked him in the back.

But there was little case for Foden's defence as he retaliated by throwing both legs up into Fernandes's midriff.

Kobbie Mainoo blocked Rayan Cherki's goalbound effort before Youri Tielemans nearly sliced Antoine Semenyo's cross into his own net as City continued to be the more threatening.

Marcus Rashford was inches away from his first United goal since December 2024 when his free-kick came crashing back off the post with United's best effort before the break.

The woodwork came to City's rescue again just after half-time when Mainoo curled onto the post from distance and the ball rebounded kindly into Gianluigi Donnarumma's grasp.

But the City sucker punch arrived on the hour mark. Haaland adjusted his body brilliantly to sweep in Josko Gvardiol's deflected cross.

A VAR review deemed Haaland was onside and that Fernandez was not interfering as he stooped to try and head in himself.

City came close to landing the telling blow when Fernandez's effort was turned out the post by Senne Lammens.

Haaland also should have had a second when he got onto Fernandez's wicked low free-kick delivery.

City, though, were not made to pay for failing to add a second as United lacked the composure and quality to make the man advantage count until the final minute of stoppage time.

Fernandes's reverse ball perfectly picked out Bryan Mbeumo but he was denied by a fine save from Donnarumma.

Arsenal and City look a class apart from the competition once more. Both are locked on 12 points.

India women bag junior Asian title

MOOI, CHINA: Sanika Chandrakant Mane's early strike proved decisive as India qualified for the junior women's Hockey World Cup by winning the AHF Junior Asia Cup title for the third time in a row after defeating China 1-0 in a closely fought summit clash, here on Sunday. Sanika struck in the 17th minute. India were unbeaten.

Indian shooters on diverted flight

NEW DELHI: Some Asian Games-bound Indian shooters were in an Air India flight from Bhopal to Delhi that was diverted to Jaipur on Sunday morning due to a technical issue. Seven shooters, four coaches and four support staff members were onboard the flight which took off from Bhopal's Raja Bhoj airport at 8.36am. They were scheduled to land in Delhi at 9:40am. However, it was diverted to Jaipur due to a technical issue.

Anahat loses thriller in Doha

DOHA: India's squash talent Anahat Singh lost to Belgian world No.9 Tinne Gilis in a five-game thriller in the second round of the Qatar Classic, a PSA Platinum event. Gilis lost the second and third games but won 11-4, 8-11, 9-11, 11-4, 11-3.